# CoRTeC: A Differentially Private Release for Synthetic Tabular Data, Decodable by Any Generator

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DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.22945315
Version 1.2.5, 30 October 2026

**Abstract.** We propose CoRTeC, a differentially private release for synthetic tabular data that separates spending the privacy budget from generating rows. CoRTeC spends the budget once, on a small release of noisy counts designed for training a classifier. For each cohort of the data, the release gives the cohort's size, its class balance, a histogram of every attribute for each outcome class, and the outcome rate in a set of non-overlapping cells. A reviewer can check every one of these numbers before the release leaves the institution. Everything after the release is post-processing and costs no further privacy. A maximum-entropy decoder can turn the counts into rows, and so can each of the five frozen language models we tested, none of which ever sees a record. A selection step then matches the decoded rows to the released counts. One release can therefore serve any number of draws, by any team and with any model, and the model can be replaced without touching the guarantee. At $\varepsilon = 2$, the auto-configured release, decoded without a language model, trains classifiers to within 0.02 AUC of a real sample of the same size on Adult, over three splits. The gap is larger on NHANES and bank marketing, reaching 0.07 AUC on the medical dataset. The fixed workload carries the conditional rates a deployment names, at some cost to pairs of columns. Four controls show where the utility comes from: the release and the selection step provide most of it, and a language model adds what it knows from the column names. No private row ever reaches a decoder, the strongest membership attack stays far below the bound the budget allows, and no synthetic row copies a training row.

## 1. Introduction

Hospitals, insurers and statistics offices hold sensitive tables that they would like to use more widely. They want to train models outside their own walls, give realistic samples to partners, and let researchers study a problem without studying the people in the data. Differentially private synthetic data [14, 15] is the accepted way to do all three. It is produced today by marginal methods, such as MST [27] and AIM [28], which fit a graphical model to marginals measured under the privacy budget [10], and by methods built on language models. These either fine-tune a model on the private rows with DP-SGD [1, 3, 38], or score a model's candidates privately [24, 39, 43].

An institution with sensitive data needs three things from such a method. First, it needs to spend its budget once, on counts it chose in advance and can review before anything leaves its walls. Second, it needs to decode those counts again later, with another team or another model, at no further privacy cost. Third, when a language model is involved, it needs to know what the model adds beyond the private statistics, because a model pretrained on public text may already know a public benchmark [10, 37]. Existing methods spend the budget as they go, inside a fitted model, a training run or rounds of candidates, so they are not designed to give these three things.

In this paper we propose CoRTeC: a differentially private release designed for training a downstream classifier, together with two ways of decoding it (Figure 1). Stage A is the only code that reads the private data. It groups the rows into cohorts and publishes four things for each cohort, all with Laplace noise: the cohort's size, its class balance, a histogram of every attribute for each outcome class, and the outcome rate in each of a set of non-overlapping cells. The workload is fixed before the release is computed, either by a public rule or by a single selection step whose cost is charged to the budget and whose output is itself released (Section 4.1). The budget is spent there, and only there. What leaves the institution is a file of counts that anyone can inspect cell by cell, and everything after it is post-processing. A maximum-entropy decoder, the same estimator AIM uses, can fit the released counts and sample rows from them. Alternatively, a frozen language model can decode the same release. It reads the release and nothing else, and it writes rows that carry exactly the counts it is asked for. A selection step then takes the rows from either decoder, matches them to the released counts, and redraws values inside their released bins. Because every reader of the release is post-processing, generation can be repeated as often as needed and on any model, including one behind an interface the institution does not control. The model becomes a replaceable part, and replacing it costs no privacy.

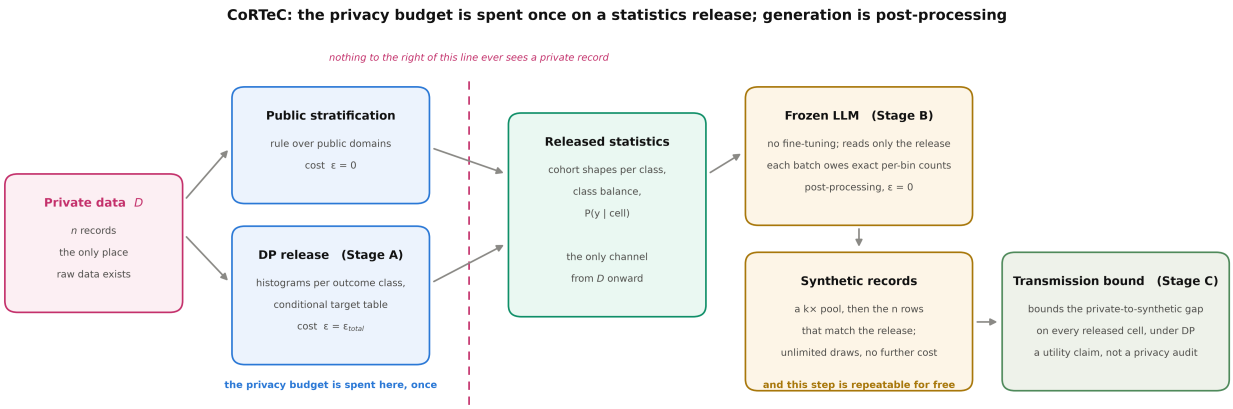



**Figure 1:** The privacy budget is spent once, in Stage A. Everything to the right of the dashed line reads only the released statistics, so it can be repeated without limit.

**What an institution gains.** The design gives an institution five things. First, the entire privacy loss is incurred by a single file, in which every number records its query, its budget and how it composes. Reviewing a release therefore means reviewing counts, not model weights or a training run. Second, the workload is set before the release is computed, so the conditional rates a deployment needs are declared up front rather than discovered round by round. Third, only the release crosses the institution's boundary. The rows never reach a model, a training cluster or a vendor, and whoever runs the decoder, even a hostile endpoint, learns nothing the release does not already say. Fourth, decoding is free and can be repeated. Another team can decode the same release at a different size, with a newer model or with no model at all, and a decoder that disappoints can be replaced without touching the guarantee. Fifth, because the model is separate from the mechanism, its contribution can be measured. We use this to test our own claims.

We evaluate CoRTeC on three datasets: Adult, NHANES and bank marketing. Every result is read against a real sample of the same size, a floor with the target shuffled and a ceiling trained on real data. Four controls separate the parts of the design. Two decode the release without a language model, with and without the selection step. One renames the schema to neutral tokens, and one writes rows from the column names with no release at all. For context, we also run the reference implementations of AIM and MST and three recent methods under their own protocols. Every table reports fidelity and utility side by side, and the central results are repeated on three splits.

The release on its own is enough to train useful models. Auto-configured and decoded without a language model, it trains every classifier we tested to within 0.02 AUC of a real sample of the same size on Adult, over three splits. On the two other datasets the gap is larger, reaching 0.07 AUC on the medical survey at 300 rows. After the selection step, the decoded rows carry the conditional rates the release names more closely than a real sample of the same size does. The cost of fixing the workload in advance falls on pairs of columns, which an adaptive workload fits more closely. What the language model adds comes from the column names: it repairs pairs it recognises, invents links between nearly independent columns, and loses its advantage under neutral names. Without the release, it copies the public file into most of its output. In every configuration, no private row reaches the model and no synthetic row copies a training row.

Our contributions are as follows.

- **The release** (Section 4.1). A single file of noisy counts carries the whole privacy loss. It holds class-conditional histograms and a conditional outcome table within cohorts, with the workload fixed before the release is computed. It satisfies pure ε-differential privacy, with a five-step proof, and it can be inspected cell by cell. An auto-configurator chooses the cohorts and the conditional levels within the same budget.
- **Two decoders and a selection step** (Section 4.2). A maximum-entropy decoder rebuilds rows at no privacy cost, and a frozen language model is guided by exact per-bin counts. Algorithm 2 matches either decoder's output to the released counts, and it accounts for most of the gain over the plain decoder.
- **A reference implementation** that ships both decoders (`cortec run` and `cortec decode`) together with the checks a deployment needs: membership inference tested on a positive control, distance to the closest record, a test of what the model has memorised, and the cost per thousand rows.

- **An evaluation** (Section 5) that reads every result against a real sample of the same size, a floor and a ceiling, reports fidelity and utility together, and replicates the central results over three splits. Four controls attribute each gain to the release, the selection step or the model, and reference methods are included for context.

A companion deployment guide covers the practical side: the reference architecture, the guardrails, and the failure modes we ran into while building the method, each with the test that catches it.

## 2. Related Work

Three families of methods are in wide use. Some measure marginals under the budget, some train a generator under the budget, and some keep a foundation model frozen. In Section 5 we run the members of each family that an institution would be most likely to consider: the reference AIM and MST, DP-2Stage, the DP-LLMTGen procedure on three backbones, and Tab-PE.

**Marginal methods.** PrivBayes [46], MST [27], PrivMRF [7] and AIM [28] select low-order marginals under the budget and fit a graphical model to them with Private-PGM [26]. MST took first place in the 2018 NIST challenge, and Bowen and Snoke compare that challenge's entries on marginal, joint and correlation measures [6]. AIM chooses its marginals adaptively, and it is our main reference from this family. The benchmark of Chen et al. [10] finds AIM and PrivMRF the most accurate across five datasets and three budgets, measured by machine-learning efficacy, 3-way query error and 2-way total variation. Tao et al. [36] reached a similar conclusion for the generative methods available at the time. Our AIM and MST rows use the authors' private-pgm implementation, run on our public bins.

**Generators trained under differential privacy.** DP-GAN [44] and DP-CTGAN [32] train a generative adversarial network with DP-SGD [1], and the second builds on CTGAN [42]. PATE-GAN [22] trains one under PATE [30, 31]. DP-TBART [8] trains an autoregressive transformer with DP-SGD and matches the marginal methods on most of its datasets, and DP-TLDM [47] trains a latent diffusion model in the same way. These papers and the benchmark evaluate them alongside the marginal methods [3, 10, 38], so we cite them rather than run them.

**Language models fine-tuned on the private rows.** GReaT [5] writes each row as text of the form "column is value" and fine-tunes GPT-2 on it, with no privacy guarantee. DP-LLMTGen [38] fine-tunes Llama-2 7B in two stages. It first learns the table format on random tables, and then it trains on the private rows with DP-SGD, using a loss that gives extra weight to the value tokens. Its authors find that meaningful feature names help the fine-tuned model. DP-2Stage [3] fine-tunes GPT-2 in a similar way, with a first stage on pseudo-data, and includes AIM among its reference points on Adult. In all of these methods, the private rows reach the training hardware, and the budget is spent on per-example gradients in every epoch.

**Methods that keep the model frozen.** Private Evolution [24] and its text version [43] generate candidates with a foundation model, let the private records vote for their nearest candidates under a Gaussian mechanism, and repeat. Tab-PE [39] replaces the model with simple variation operators, and it shows that marginal methods miss high-order correlations that the standard benchmarks do not test. Swanberg et al. [37] adapt Private Evolution to tabular data. They also try rows generated in one shot from the column names, used as public data inside a marginal mechanism. On Adult, they find that neither approach improves on the marginal baselines, and that the one-shot rows reproduce single columns but not pairs [37]. We run Tab-PE [39] and the one-shot setting as well. CoRTeC differs from both in what the model is given: a differentially private release of conditional statistics, which the selection step then enforces. Table 1 summarises the differences.

**Table 1:** What each method needs. The budget column says where the privacy loss is incurred.

| method | model weights | private rows seen by | public or side data | budget spent on | adaptive rounds | backbone swap |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| CoRTeC | no; any inference interface | Stage A only; the model never sees a row | column names and value lists | one release of counts, composed once | none | at no privacy cost |
| AIM, MST | none | the measured marginals | public domains and bins | measured marginals; AIM selects adaptively | AIM yes | not applicable |
| DP-2Stage | GPT-2, full fine-tune | the DP-SGD trainer | pseudo data (uniform over private ranges, or a public table) | per-sample gradients, every step | yes | retrain |
| DP-LLMTGen | Llama-2 7B, LoRA | the DP-SGD trainer | random tables from names, categories and ranges | per-sample gradients, every step | yes | retrain |

| method | model weights | private rows seen by | public or side data | budget spent on | adaptive rounds | backbone swap |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Tab-PE | none | the nearest-neighbour histogram, every iteration | numerical bounds; class counts | Gaussian noise on the histogram, 15 to 30 rounds | yes | not applicable |
| one-shot records [37] | no | none by the model; the downstream mechanism | column names and types | inside the downstream mechanism | depends | at no privacy cost |

## 3. Preliminaries and Privacy Model

A dataset $D$ is a multiset of $n$ records over attributes $A = A_{num} \cup A_{cat}$, together with a binary target $y$. Each attribute has a public domain: an interval for a numerical attribute, and a finite set of values for a categorical one. Public bin edges divide each numerical domain into bins, and $M_a(D)$ denotes the histogram of attribute $a$ over its bins. For a cell $c$ of the record space, $k_c(D)$ is the number of records in $c$ with $y = 1$. Two datasets are neighbours if one can be obtained from the other by adding or removing a single record.

**Definition 1 (Differential privacy [14]).** *A randomised mechanism $M$ is $\varepsilon$-differentially private if for all neighbours $D$, $D'$ and all sets $S$ of outputs, $Pr[M(D) \in S] \leq e^{\varepsilon} Pr[M(D') \in S]$.*

The Laplace mechanism adds $\mathrm{Lap}(\Delta/\varepsilon)$ noise to a function of L1 sensitivity $\Delta$, and it is $\varepsilon$-differentially private [14]. A histogram over any number of bins has $\Delta = 1$, and so does a counting query. Mechanisms run on the same data compose sequentially, which means that their budgets add up [15]. Mechanisms run on disjoint parts of the data compose in parallel, provided that the parts are defined by a rule that does not depend on the data. Together, they cost only the largest of their budgets [29]. Any computation on the output of a private mechanism that does not look at $D$ again is post-processing, and it costs nothing [15]. Definition 1 also limits what any membership attacker can achieve. No test of whether a record is in $D$ can have a true-positive rate that exceeds its false-positive rate by more than $(e^{\varepsilon} - 1)/(e^{\varepsilon} + 1)$, which is 0.762 at $\varepsilon = 2$.

**Threat model.** The adversary has unlimited computing power and sees everything that crosses the trust boundary: the release $R$, every synthetic dataset drawn from it, and the model's inputs and outputs. The institution's data extract, the schema and the release engine all run inside its perimeter, and they are the only code that reads $D$. The generator, the selection step and everything downstream read only $R$ and their own output. Whoever operates the model, including a hostile endpoint, therefore learns nothing that $R$ does not reveal, and $R$ is $\varepsilon$-differentially private.

**Privacy model.** The guarantee is pure $\varepsilon$-differential privacy ($\delta = 0$) in the central model, under add/remove adjacency, and it protects one row. When each person contributes one row, it protects a person. When a person can contribute several rows, as with hospital encounters, the per-person $\varepsilon$ is multiplied by the largest number of rows any one person contributes. The reference implementation therefore requires that number to be declared. As in every marginal method, two things are treated as public: the list of attributes with their domains and bins, and the rule that forms the cohorts. Cohort sizes, class balances and cell sizes are private counts, so they are released with noise rather than assumed. The model's pretraining corpus falls outside the guarantee. If a private record was in it, that record was exposed before CoRTeC ever ran. Like prior work, we treat a public pretrained model as public [37, 40], and we measure the consequence that matters: whether anything the model has memorised reaches a draw (Section 5.5).

## 4. CoRTeC: the Release and its Decoders

CoRTeC has three stages (Figure 1). Stage A is the only code that reads $D$, and it produces the release $R$. Stage B decodes $R$, either with a maximum-entropy model or with a frozen language model, and passes the decoder's output through a selection step. It reads only $R$ and its own output. Stage C is optional and has its own budget. It bounds how far the synthetic conditional rates are from the private ones.

### 4.1 Stage A: the release

**Algorithm 1: CoRTeC-Release**

**Input:** private $D$; public schema (domains, bin edges, stratification rule $\Pi$, conditional levels $L_0 \subset \ldots \subset L_k$); budget $\varepsilon_{total}$; conditional share $\alpha$; count share $\gamma$; suppression floor $n_{min}$

**Output:** release $R$

(1) $\varepsilon_{count} \leftarrow \gamma\, \varepsilon_{total}$; $\varepsilon_{marg} \leftarrow (1 - \alpha)(\varepsilon_{total} - \varepsilon_{count})$; $\varepsilon_{cond} \leftarrow \alpha\, (\varepsilon_{total} - \varepsilon_{count})$

(2) $q \leftarrow |A| + 1$ queries per cohort; $\varepsilon_q \leftarrow \varepsilon_{marg} / q$; $\varepsilon_L \leftarrow \varepsilon_{cond} / |L|$

(3) For each cohort $P$ the rule $\Pi$ can form, holding records or not:

  (4) $\tilde{n_P} \leftarrow |P| + \text{Lap}(1/\varepsilon_{count})$; if $\tilde{n_P} < n_{min}$ continue; release $\tilde{n_P}$

  (5) release the two-bin histogram of $y$ on $P$, each count + $\text{Lap}(1/\varepsilon_q)$

  (6) if both noised class counts are at least $n_{min}$: for $c \in \{0, 1\}$ and $a \in A$ release $M_a(P \cap \{y = c\}) + \text{Lap}(1/\varepsilon_q)$

  (7) else: for $a \in A$ release $M_a(P) + \text{Lap}(1/\varepsilon_q)$ (pooled block)

(8) For each level $\ell \in L$ and each cell $c$ of its public domain, holding records or not:

  (9) $\tilde{k_c} \leftarrow k_c(D) + \text{Lap}(2/\varepsilon_L)$; $\tilde{n_c} \leftarrow |c| + \text{Lap}(2/\varepsilon_L)$; if $\tilde{n_c} < n_{min}$ continue

  (10) release $\tilde{\rho_c} \leftarrow \text{clip}(\tilde{k_c} / \max(\tilde{n_c}, n_{min}), 0, 1)$

(11) Return $R$ with every released quantity, its $\varepsilon$, sensitivity and composition rule

Four design choices keep the release cheap. First, the cohorts come from a rule over public domains, so forming them costs nothing. Because the cohorts do not overlap, their queries also compose in parallel. Second, the release uses histograms rather than means and standard deviations. A histogram has sensitivity 1 however many bins it has, so the whole shape of a distribution costs the same as a single count. Third, giving each outcome class its own block of histograms costs no more than a single pooled block, because the two class blocks do not overlap. The pooled histogram is simply their mixture under the released class balance, which is post-processing. A cohort whose smaller class falls below $n_{min}$ keeps a pooled block instead. Fourth, the conditional table is released over the cells of a partition, so each level receives its full budget $\varepsilon_L$ however many cells it contains. Each cell's rate is the ratio of two noised counts whose noise does not depend on anything private, and this keeps the mechanism pure $\varepsilon$. Noising the rate directly would need noise scaled to the private cell size, which would not be pure $\varepsilon$. Every decision involving $n_{min}$ compares a noised, charged count with the public floor, so which cohorts and cells appear in $R$ depends only on released quantities. An auto-configurator can also choose $\Pi$ and $L$ from the schema, the budget and the requested size. Its only step that reads $D$, a noised contingency table for each candidate column, is charged to the budget (Appendix D).

**Example 1 (one cohort of a release).** Take the seed-42 Adult release at $\varepsilon = 2$. Every fixed-rule Adult configuration in Section 5 decodes this release, and the anonymised ones decode it under neutral names. The release forms twelve cohorts from four education bands and three bands of weekly hours. Consider the cohort of graduates who work forty hours a week. With $\gamma = 0.02$, the cohort-size query has $\varepsilon_{count} = 0.04$, so Stage A releases the true size plus Laplace noise at scale 25. The released size is 762. The class-balance query and the fourteen histograms share $\varepsilon_{marg} = 1.568$. That makes fifteen queries at $\varepsilon_q = 0.105$ each, so every count carries noise at scale 9.6. The two noised class counts give a balance of 0.551 above 50K and 0.449 at or below it. Both counts exceed $n_{min} = 150$, so the cohort receives a separate block of histograms for each class. In the block above 50K, age puts 0.216 of its mass in the 40 to 45 bin and none below 25. Relationship is 0.744 husband and 0.179 not in a family. In the block at or below 50K, age puts 0.140 in the 25 to 30 bin and 0.049 below 25, while relationship is 0.282 husband and 0.419 not in a family. A category whose noised count fell below the floor is listed as suppressed and receives zero weight in the selection step. Here, that applies to other relative, own child and unmarried above 50K, and to other relative at or below it. The two levels of the conditional table share $\varepsilon_{cond} = 0.392$. Level 0 is a single cell holding the overall rate, 0.241. Level 3 crosses education, hours and marital status, which gives this cohort two cells: 0.739 for married people and 0.210 for everyone else. Each rate is the ratio of two counts noised at scale 10.2, with the denominator held at or above the public floor. That is everything about this cohort that leaves the institution: a size, two class counts, twenty-eight histograms, a list of suppressed categories and two rates, each with its $\varepsilon$ recorded beside it.

Now follow the cohort through Stage B. At $n = 300$, with a pool factor of 3, the cohort is allotted 26 pool rows in proportion to its released size. The released balance assigns 14 of them to the class above 50K and 12 to the class below. Each class block then fixes how many rows each bin must hold, using the largest-remainder rule. Above 50K, that means three rows aged 40 to 45 and ten husbands. Below 50K, it means two rows aged 25 to 30 and five people

not in a family. The prompt states these counts, and the language model writes rows that carry them. The maximum-entropy decoder needs no prompt, and it samples its fitted distribution at the same pool size. The selection step then matches every cohort's pool to the released counts, keeps about nine rows of this cohort in the final 300, and refines them by swapping rows. Finally, it redraws each numerical value inside its released bin. The rows that leave therefore carry the release's structure down to the level of a bin, and nothing of the model's below it. Figure 2 shows the two class blocks of this cohort as released.

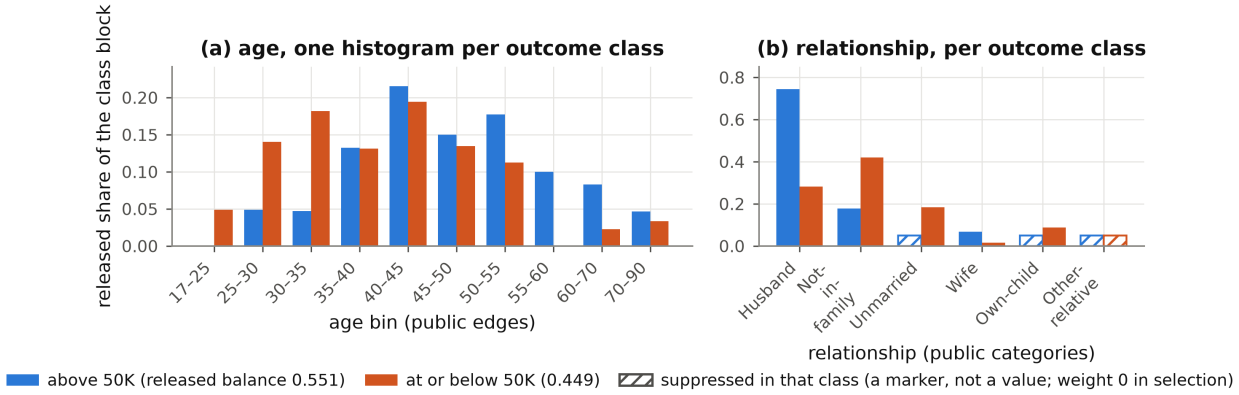



**Figure 2:** The cohort of Example 1 as it leaves the institution. (a) The age histogram released for each outcome class, over the public bin edges. (b) The relationship shares for each class. Hatched markers show categories whose noised count fell below the floor, and these receive zero weight in the selection step. Every bar is a released number. The decoders read these numbers, the class balance, the cohort size and the two conditional cells, and nothing else.

### 4.2 Stage B: exact counts, selection and the sub-bin rule

Stage B divides the requested rows among the cohorts in proportion to their released sizes. From the released histograms, it works out exact counts for every bin, category and class. It then asks the frozen model for batches of 25 rows that carry whatever counts the cohort still owes. The prompt (Appendix D) contains the release and the counts, but never a record. It states the counts separately for each outcome class, and it tells the model to follow the released statistics even where they contradict its expectations. Rows that parse, lie within their domains and use declared categories go into a pool $k$ times the requested size, with $k = 3$ on Adult and bank marketing and $k = 2$ on NHANES. Generation runs cohort by cohort rather than cell by cell. A cell-by-cell variant we tried produced nothing for the people the released cells did not name. It dropped whole subgroups while every aggregate check still passed. This is the kind of disparate impact that Ganev et al. document for differentially private synthesis [17], and the reference implementation refuses that path below a coverage floor (see the deployment guide).

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**Algorithm 2: CoRTeC-Select**

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**Input:** release $R$; pool $D\hat{}$; requested size $m$

**Output:** synthetic dataset $D^*$ of $m$ rows

(1) Require that every cohort $P$ holds at least $m\ n\tilde{}_P / \Sigma\ n\tilde{}$ pool rows and a tenth more (coverage guard)

(2) $w \leftarrow$ inclusion weights by iterative proportional fitting [12] of $D\hat{}$ to every released cell: cohort sizes, class balances and every histogram; a suppressed category receives weight 0

(3) $D^* \leftarrow$ a systematic sample of $m$ rows under $w$ (rake)

(4) Swap a row of $D^*$ for a pool row whenever the swap lowers the weighted L1 distance between the cell counts of $D^*$ and $R$, until no swap improves it (refine)

(5) In every cohort with class blocks, redraw each numerical value uniformly inside its released bin intersected with its stratification band; integer columns draw integers (sub-bin rule)

(6) Return $D^*$

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Exact counts make the pool match the release closely. Even so, any $m$ rows drawn from a faithful pool still carry sampling error, and the selection step removes it. The sub-bin rule then handles the structure inside each bin. A released histogram fixes the count in each bin and nothing finer, so where a value falls within its bin should come from the release, not from the model. Each step reads only $R$, the generated rows and fresh randomness. Whether a

numerical column holds integers is decided from the public bin edges and bounds, together with the majority of the pool's values. A rule that looked at every value let a single model-written "45.0" turn a whole column into real-valued redraws. Every draw in this paper is scored with the majority rule in place (Appendix D).

**The maximum-entropy decoder.** To measure what the language model contributes, we also decode the same release with no model at all. The decoder fits the maximum-entropy distribution that agrees with every released count, using Private-PGM [26], and samples from it at the same $n$. Since it reads only $R$, it spends no budget, and every language-model result in Section 5 is read against it. Private-PGM is also the estimator behind AIM, so what CoRTeC contributes is the workload, not the inference engine. The release is a fixed workload: class-conditional single-column marginals within cohorts, plus the conditional cells, all chosen before the release is computed. It gives the conditional rates a deployment names, a file a reader can inspect cell by cell, and a release computed in seconds. An adaptive workload fits pairs of columns more closely (Section 5.4).

**Stage C.** For each released cell, the private data has a positive rate $p_c$ and the synthetic data has a public rate $q_c$. Stage C releases a Laplace estimate of $p_c$, with the denominator held at or above the public floor, at a declared budget $\varepsilon_{cert}$. It turns that estimate into a bound on $|p_c - q_c|$ that holds for all cells at once. It gives no verdict unless two conditions are met. A real hold-out sample must pass the tolerance while the same sample with its target shuffled fails it, and every cell must hold at least 20 synthetic rows. The bound concerns utility only (Appendix E.8).

### 4.3 Privacy analysis

**Theorem 1.** *Algorithms 1 and 2, together with the generation step, are $\varepsilon_{total}$-differentially private. With auto-configuration, the total is $\varepsilon_{sel} + \varepsilon_{release} = \varepsilon_{total}$. Stage C adds $\varepsilon_{cert}$.*

The proof (Appendix A) has five composition steps. (i) Forming the cohorts reads only public domains, so it is free. (ii) Within a cohort, the class-balance query and the $|A|$ histograms of a record's own class block form a chain of $q$ Laplace queries of sensitivity 1, which compose sequentially to $\varepsilon_{marg}$. The two class blocks do not overlap, so they compose in parallel. (iii) Across cohorts, the queries compose in parallel, because each record lies in exactly one cohort. (iv) Within a conditional level, the cells partition $D$ and compose in parallel. A cell's two counts compose sequentially to $\varepsilon_L$, and the published rate is post-processing of those two counts and the public floor. (v) The levels describe the same people, so their budgets add up to $\varepsilon_{cond}$. The cohort sizes cost $\varepsilon_{count}$, again in parallel across cohorts. Generation, selection and the sub-bin rule read only $R$, the generated rows and fresh randomness. By post-processing, they add nothing, whatever the pool factor and however many draws are made. Summing the three parts gives $\varepsilon_{count} + \varepsilon_{marg} + \varepsilon_{cond} = \varepsilon_{total}$.

## 5. Experiments

We evaluate CoRTeC on three public datasets. As reference points, we run the reference implementations of AIM and MST, as well as DP-2Stage, the DP-LLMTGen procedure and Tab-PE, both on our split and under each paper's own protocol. We also run the four controls described in Section 1. Utility is the measure on which a deployment is judged, but we report fidelity beside it in every table, because the synthetic rows themselves are also handed out.

### 5.1 Setup

**Table 2:** Datasets. Every split uses seed 42. The replication seeds, 43 and 44, each draw a fresh split and a fresh release.

| dataset | records | train / test | numerical / categorical | target, positive rate | role |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| UCI Adult [13, 23] | 32,561 | 26,048 / 6,513 | 6 / 8 | income over 50K, 24.1 % | every comparison, the controls, the ladder, the replication |
| NHANES 2017-2018 [9] | 3,749 adults | 2,999 / 750 | 5 / 4 | HbA1c at or above 6.5 %, 14.2 % | auto-configured clinical dataset, the replication |
| bank marketing [25] | 45,211 | 36,168 / 9,043 | 5 / 8 | term deposit, 11.7 % | third dataset, one split |

**Reference methods.** The reference AIM and MST are the authors' private-pgm implementation (mbi 1.1), whose empirical privacy Ganev et al. audit and find close to the stated guarantee [16]. We fit both on the training split, with the same public bins that CoRTeC declares, at the same $\varepsilon$, and with a corrected sampler. AIM runs under the stable message-passing oracle, with a check that the fitted marginals agree with the noisy measurements. MST, and the AIM

and MST rows at $\varepsilon = 0.5$ and 1 in Appendix E.7, run under the library's default oracle. Appendix D gives the settings, explains the choice of oracle and shows how closely the two oracles agree on the seed-42 split. DP-2Stage runs the authors' code (GPT-2, DP-SGD, $\delta = 10^{-5}$) on our split. For the DP fine-tuning rows, we apply DP-LLMTGen's two-stage LoRA [20] procedure and loss to Qwen3-14B, Qwen2.5-7B and Llama-2 7B on our split ($\delta = 10^{-5}$), so that the same backbone appears under two privacy designs. Tab-PE runs the authors' code with a population of 1,000 rows (600 on NHANES) and $\delta = 1/(n \ln n)$, and its own evaluator, TabICL [19], scores the Tab-PE protocol rows. Two controls complete a two-by-two design over the release and the model. The release without a model is the maximum-entropy decoder of Section 4.2, alone and with the selection step. The release with a model is CoRTeC itself. The model without a release writes rows from the column names alone, which is the baseline Swanberg et al. use [37]. The permuted-target floor has neither.

**CoRTeC configuration.** One set of settings was fixed before any experiment. The budget is $\varepsilon = 2$, with $\alpha = 0.2$, $\gamma = 0.02$ and $n_{\min} = 150$. Each batch asks for 25 rows, with the counts stated separately for each outcome class. The pool factor is 3 (2 on NHANES), and every draw passes through the selection step with the sub-bin rule. NHANES and bank marketing use the auto-configurator to choose their cohorts and conditional levels, while Adult uses the hand-written rule in its schema. Since the auto-configurator is the shipped default, we also ran it on Adult after the main experiments. We did this for consistency, not as a search over configurations. On each split, the released Stage A chooses the cohorts and the hierarchy and charges that choice to the same budget. It spends a count share of 0.05, plus the gate charge, instead of 0.02 (Appendix D). This release is decoded with no model and with the selection step only, and it is labelled "auto-configured, no model, with selection" wherever it appears. The language-model backbones are Qwen3-8B, Qwen3-14B and Qwen3-32B (4-bit AWQ), served locally through vLLM, and Gemini 3.6 Flash, which Google's interface has served under the Gemini 3.5 Flash identifier since 8 October 2026. Qwen3-14B is the primary backbone. A Qwen2.5-7B configuration appears only where a protocol was run on it (Appendix E.6).

**The privacy budget.** Recent papers, including those on the adversarial generators, report $\varepsilon = 1$ as their headline [3, 38], and the benchmark of Chen et al. uses 0.2, 1 and 5. Our headline of $\varepsilon = 2$ comes from the release itself. On the shipped split, each count in a conditional cell is noised at scale 10.2, so a cell at the floor of 150 records carries its rate to within about 0.1. At $\varepsilon = 1$ and 0.5, that error grows to about 0.2 and 0.4. The conditional table then stops being informative near the floor, and a comparison would measure the noise rather than the methods. We therefore chose $\varepsilon = 2$ as the budget at which a cell of floor size still carries its rate to within a tenth of the range. This is a design choice rather than a measured threshold, and we do not claim that a trade-off seen at $\varepsilon = 2$ disappears below it. Appendices E.6 and E.7 report every method at a budget its own paper uses, and the picture is the same at every budget.

**Metrics.** We measure fidelity in four ways against the full private training table, over the public bins. 1-way and 2-way total variation compare single columns and pairs of columns. Conditional total variation compares $P(y \mid \text{group})$ over two families of groups: the cohort bands that the release describes ("seen"), and groups built from columns that share nothing with the conditioning ("held-out"). Utility is train-on-synthetic, test-on-real (TSTR) AUC [32]. We train three classifiers, which we call students, on the synthetic table (logistic regression, a random forest and gradient boosting) and test them on the real test split. Appendix B gives the definitions. Each paper protocol in Appendix E.6 uses that paper's own metrics and split.

**Floors, ceiling and repetition.** Every table carries three references at the same $n$. The first is a real sample of $n$ training rows, which a synthetic table of the same size is not expected to exceed. The second is the same rows with the target shuffled, a floor that carries no information. The third is the ceiling: the students trained on a real sample of 4,000 training rows (the whole split on NHANES, which has 2,999). A metric that cannot separate the first two references has no power, so we checked that every metric could do so before reading any table. Measuring against explicit reference points rather than a bare threshold is the practice DPBench recommends [18]. Every cell is the mean over three draws, with the sample standard deviation. The central cells are repeated on seeds 43 and 44 with fresh splits and releases, and the paired differences across seeds are reported with their sign count and a paired t-test. Results from a single split or draw are labelled as such and read as signals only. With three seeds a paired test has little power, so we treat a difference as replicated when its sign is the same at every seed.

## 5.2 Without a language model, the release trains models close to a real sample

**Table 3:** Adult at $\varepsilon = 2$ on the seed-42 split. Fidelity is total variation (lower is better), and utility is train-on-synthetic, test-on-real AUC (higher is better). Each cell is the mean ± standard deviation over three draws (five for the reference MST; the ceiling is a single fit). The reference rows are in italics. The Gemini configuration was run at $n = 300$ only. The decoder-with-selection row is the release decoded with no model and passed through Algorithm 2, on a pool three times the size of $n$. The one-shot row is the Gemini backbone writing

rows from the column names alone, with no release (Appendix D). The auto-configured row is the release that the auto-configurator derives on Adult (Section 5.1), decoded with no model and with the selection step. Its conditional cells are not comparable (n/a; Appendix E.2). Appendix F gives the membership advantage of every configuration.

### $n$ = 300

| condition | 1-way TV ↓ | 2-way TV ↓ | cond. seen ↓ | cond. held-out ↓ | TSTR-LR ↑ | TSTR-RF ↑ | TSTR-GBM ↑ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *real sample of 4,000 rows (utility ceiling)* | *0.011* | *0.028* | *0.020* | *0.008* | *0.860* | *0.907* | *0.914* |
| *real sample of n rows (floor)* | *0.043 ± 0.005* | *0.107 ± 0.004* | *0.062 ± 0.031* | *0.036 ± 0.001* | *0.830 ± 0.013* | *0.870 ± 0.016* | *0.840 ± 0.022* |
| *permuted target (no information)* | *0.041 ± 0.002* | *0.110 ± 0.000* | *0.152 ± 0.045* | *0.102 ± 0.013* | *0.423 ± 0.200* | *0.485 ± 0.127* | *0.482 ± 0.107* |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B | 0.046 ± 0.011 | 0.139 ± 0.010 | 0.027 ± 0.011 | 0.048 ± 0.016 | 0.807 ± 0.026 | 0.862 ± 0.015 | 0.833 ± 0.019 |
| CoRTeC, Gemini 3.6 Flash | 0.027 ± 0.001 | 0.110 ± 0.001 | 0.013 ± 0.008 | 0.042 ± 0.010 | 0.805 ± 0.013 | 0.863 ± 0.008 | 0.838 ± 0.005 |
| maximum-entropy decoder of the release | 0.058 ± 0.001 | 0.146 ± 0.002 | 0.082 ± 0.018 | 0.049 ± 0.011 | 0.818 ± 0.020 | 0.856 ± 0.017 | 0.847 ± 0.009 |
| maximum-entropy decoder with the selection step | 0.033 ± 0.011 | 0.118 ± 0.006 | 0.014 ± 0.006 | 0.048 ± 0.011 | 0.824 ± 0.009 | 0.866 ± 0.004 | 0.862 ± 0.006 |
| auto-configured release, no model, with selection | 0.019 ± 0.002 | 0.108 ± 0.001 | n/a | n/a | 0.826 ± 0.016 | 0.873 ± 0.009 | 0.860 ± 0.006 |
| reference AIM | 0.056 ± 0.005 | 0.122 ± 0.001 | 0.055 ± 0.007 | 0.047 ± 0.015 | 0.845 ± 0.004 | 0.869 ± 0.012 | 0.845 ± 0.012 |
| reference MST | 0.048 ± 0.005 | 0.121 ± 0.004 | 0.140 ± 0.021 | 0.043 ± 0.006 | 0.733 ± 0.051 | 0.802 ± 0.021 | 0.748 ± 0.035 |
| DP-2Stage, GPT-2 | 0.280 ± 0.006 | 0.465 ± 0.007 | 0.147 ± 0.005 | 0.141 ± 0.020 | 0.598 ± 0.090 | 0.607 ± 0.155 | 0.601 ± 0.205 |
| DP fine-tuned Qwen3-14B | 0.106 ± 0.004 | 0.190 ± 0.002 | 0.087 ± 0.020 | 0.071 ± 0.008 | 0.809 ± 0.025 | 0.832 ± 0.010 | 0.815 ± 0.007 |
| Tab-PE | 0.203 ± 0.002 | 0.366 ± 0.004 | 0.134 ± 0.002 | 0.049 ± 0.005 | 0.812 ± 0.026 | 0.856 ± 0.013 | 0.839 ± 0.013 |
| one-shot from the column names, Gemini 3.6 Flash (no release) | 0.148 ± 0.002 | 0.307 ± 0.002 | 0.214 ± 0.014 | 0.136 ± 0.007 | 0.795 ± 0.009 | 0.850 ± 0.001 | 0.831 ± 0.012 |

### $n$ = 1,000

| condition | 1-way TV ↓ | 2-way TV ↓ | cond. seen ↓ | cond. held-out ↓ | TSTR-LR ↑ | TSTR-RF ↑ | TSTR-GBM ↑ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *real sample of n rows (floor)* | *0.026 ± 0.004* | *0.061 ± 0.003* | *0.031 ± 0.012* | *0.019 ± 0.002* | *0.855 ± 0.001* | *0.892 ± 0.002* | *0.883 ± 0.004* |
| *permuted target (no information)* | *0.025 ± 0.002* | *0.069 ± 0.003* | *0.146 ± 0.015* | *0.095 ± 0.003* | *0.511 ± 0.119* | *0.508 ± 0.085* | *0.513 ± 0.065* |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B | 0.036 ± 0.002 | 0.108 ± 0.004 | 0.022 ± 0.002 | 0.031 ± 0.005 | 0.827 ± 0.016 | 0.860 ± 0.007 | 0.859 ± 0.007 |
| maximum-entropy decoder of the release | 0.041 ± 0.003 | 0.106 ± 0.005 | 0.034 ± 0.014 | 0.045 ± 0.009 | 0.826 ± 0.008 | 0.870 ± 0.004 | 0.863 ± 0.011 |
| maximum-entropy decoder with the selection step | 0.027 ± 0.004 | 0.089 ± 0.003 | 0.008 ± 0.002 | 0.037 ± 0.003 | 0.836 ± 0.006 | 0.873 ± 0.004 | 0.874 ± 0.007 |
| auto-configured release, no model, with selection | 0.016 ± 0.000 | 0.081 ± 0.001 | n/a | n/a | 0.841 ± 0.003 | 0.884 ± 0.002 | 0.884 ± 0.003 |
| reference AIM | 0.029 ± 0.003 | 0.072 ± 0.003 | 0.028 ± 0.007 | 0.030 ± 0.005 | 0.854 ± 0.002 | 0.888 ± 0.006 | 0.883 ± 0.010 |
| reference MST | 0.031 ± 0.003 | 0.083 ± 0.004 | 0.132 ± 0.017 | 0.044 ± 0.013 | 0.788 ± 0.029 | 0.818 ± 0.017 | 0.804 ± 0.016 |
| DP-2Stage, GPT-2 | 0.277 ± 0.005 | 0.454 ± 0.006 | 0.138 ± 0.020 | 0.133 ± 0.007 | 0.527 ± 0.113 | 0.485 ± 0.038 | 0.484 ± 0.033 |
| DP fine-tuned Qwen3-14B | 0.100 ± 0.003 | 0.172 ± 0.003 | 0.050 ± 0.010 | 0.054 ± 0.008 | 0.809 ± 0.033 | 0.845 ± 0.007 | 0.836 ± 0.012 |
| Tab-PE | 0.196 ± 0.001 | 0.350 ± 0.002 | 0.101 ± 0.017 | 0.031 ± 0.003 | 0.819 ± 0.011 | 0.854 ± 0.011 | 0.843 ± 0.007 |
| one-shot from the column names, Gemini 3.6 Flash (no release) | 0.146 ± 0.002 | 0.305 ± 0.003 | 0.191 ± 0.009 | 0.137 ± 0.005 | 0.807 ± 0.004 | 0.860 ± 0.007 | 0.844 ± 0.012 |

**The release on its own trains models close to a real sample.** On Adult, we decode the auto-configured release with no model and with the selection step. Over three splits, it trains every student to within 0.02 AUC of a real sample of the same size. On NHANES and bank marketing, we decoded the release with no model and without the selection step, and there the gap to a real sample is larger, reaching 0.07 AUC on NHANES at $n$ = 300 (Appendices E.1 and E.5). Table 3 gives the seed-42 split, and Figure 3 the means over three seeds. Every paired difference quoted below is in Appendix E.2.

On Adult at $n$ = 1,000, the maximum-entropy decoder and CoRTeC differ by at most 0.005 in either direction across the three seeds. This holds for single columns, pairs, the seen conditionals and every student. None of these differences reaches $p < 0.1$. On the held-out conditionals, CoRTeC is better by 0.009 ($p = 0.07$). At $n$ = 300, the decoder is worse on the seen conditionals (0 of 3 seeds in its favour, $p = 0.04$) and better on the gradient-boosting student (3 of 3, $p = 0.01$). On NHANES, the decoder fits pairs more closely than CoRTeC at every seed, and it scores higher on every student at $n$ = 1,000. On bank marketing, with one split, it matches the real sample on single columns (Appendix E.5). Under the three paper protocols, it is within 0.01 of CoRTeC on every utility measure (Appendix E.6).

Passing the decoder's own pool through Algorithm 2, as every CoRTeC configuration does, closes the remaining gap, and the result holds on all three splits. The decoder with selection has lower error than the plain decoder on every fidelity measure (0 of 3 seeds against, $p \leq 0.03$, except for the held-out conditionals at $n$ = 300). Its error is below that of a real sample of the same size on the seen conditionals at both sizes, and on single columns at $n$ = 300. The release that the auto-configurator derives on Adult, decoded in the same way, improves further. On the seed-42 split, its single-column error is 0.019 at $n$ = 300 and 0.016 at $n$ = 1,000, against a real sample's 0.043 and 0.026 (Table 3). Its students score 0.826, 0.873 and 0.860 at $n$ = 300, against the real sample's 0.830, 0.870 and 0.840.

### 5.3 What each part contributes

**Most of the gain comes from the selection step, not from the model.** On single columns, the auto-configured release improves on the plain decoder by 0.038 at $n$ = 300 and by 0.025 at $n$ = 1,000. Of that, the selection step accounts for 0.023 and 0.014, and the auto-configured workload for 0.015 and 0.011, each with 0 of 3 seeds against ($p \leq 0.03$). On the students, each step adds 0.003 to 0.009, which is significant only for the selection step on the forest at $n$ = 1,000 ($p = 0.01$).

Compared with the plain decoder, the model's overall effect is neutral on Adult. It is negative on NHANES pairs at every seed ($p \leq 0.02$ at both sizes) and on bank marketing at both sizes (Appendix E.5). Its one consistent gain, on the seen conditionals on Adult at $n$ = 300 (3 of 3 seeds, $p = 0.04$), comes from the selection step and not from the model. The decoder's own pool, passed through Algorithm 2, does better than both (0 of 3 seeds in the plain decoder's favour, $p \leq 0.01$). Looking pair by pair, the model's error is below the decoder's on pairs it recognises as logically linked. Examples are education with education number and marital status with relationship on Adult, and days since contact with the previous outcome on bank marketing. Its error is above the decoder's on pairs it believes are related when the data says they are not, such as education with contact, and loan with contact, on bank marketing (Appendix E.3). In short, the model repairs what it knows and invents what it expects. Without the release, the same Gemini backbone, writing rows from the column names alone, is worse than the shuffled floor on the seen conditionals. About 70 % of its rows are verbatim copies of the first 25 rows of the public file (Appendix F.3), yet its students stay within 0.025 AUC of every CoRTeC configuration. On a public benchmark, then, the fidelity columns separate the configurations and the utility columns barely do. This is a sharper form of Swanberg et al.'s finding [37]. With the release, the same backbone copies none of those rows.

**Take away the column names and the model's advantage goes with them.** The anonymised schema renames every column, category and label to a neutral token. The release and the prompt are mapped in the same way, and the draws are mapped back before scoring, so the model sees the same numbers with no meaning attached (Appendix C). Table 4 gives the results on Adult at $n$ = 300. On Gemini 3.6 Flash, the pair error rises to the decoder's level and the students fall below the decoder's. Only the advantage on single columns survives, and it belongs to the selection step. The single-column error stays at 0.030, against the decoder's 0.058, because the selection step matches the pool to the released marginals whatever the names are. On Qwen3-14B, every measure is worse without names, and the same holds for Qwen3-32B over two draws. This matches DP-LLMTGen's finding that meaningful names help a fine-tuned model [38].

**Table 4:** The anonymised-schema control on Adult at $\varepsilon = 2$ and $n$ = 300, using the same releases under neutral names. The 32B configuration has two draws and the others three.

| backbone | names | 1-way TV ↓ | 2-way TV ↓ | cond. seen ↓ | cond. held-out ↓ | TSTR-LR ↑ | TSTR-RF ↑ | TSTR-GBM ↑ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Gemini 3.6 Flash | real | 0.027 | 0.110 | 0.013 | 0.042 | 0.805 | 0.863 | 0.838 |
| Gemini 3.6 Flash | neutral | 0.030 | 0.148 | 0.014 | 0.044 | 0.745 | 0.840 | 0.798 |
| Qwen3-14B | real | 0.046 | 0.139 | 0.027 | 0.048 | 0.807 | 0.862 | 0.833 |

| backbone | names | 1-way TV ↓ | 2-way TV ↓ | cond. seen ↓ | cond. held-out ↓ | TSTR-LR ↑ | TSTR-RF ↑ | TSTR-GBM ↑ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Qwen3-14B | neutral | 0.065 | 0.168 | 0.044 | 0.054 | 0.811 | 0.846 | 0.817 |
| Qwen3-32B (AWQ) | real | 0.049 | 0.138 | 0.031 | 0.046 | 0.815 | 0.864 | 0.840 |
| Qwen3-32B (AWQ) | neutral, 2 draws | 0.060 | 0.159 | 0.067 | 0.052 | 0.785 | 0.858 | 0.822 |
| *maximum-entropy decoder* | *none* | *0.058* | *0.146* | *0.082* | *0.049* | *0.818* | *0.856* | *0.847* |
| *real sample* | | *0.043* | *0.107* | *0.062* | *0.036* | *0.830* | *0.870* | *0.840* |

## 5.4 Replication, and the cost of a fixed workload

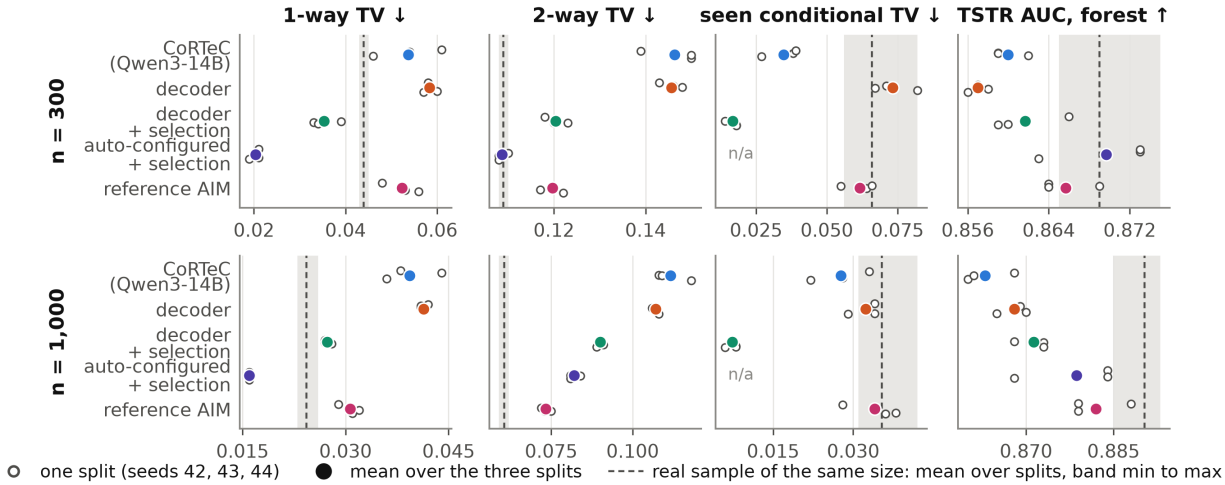



**Figure 3:** Replication on Adult over seeds 42, 43 and 44, each with a fresh split and a fresh release. An open circle is one split's mean over three draws, and a filled dot is the mean over the three splits. The dashed line and the grey band show a real sample of the same size: its mean, and its range over the splits. Four of the seven measures are shown, at both sizes. The auto-configured release's conditional cells are not comparable (n/a). Appendix E.2 gives every seed, every measure, the standard deviations across seeds and every paired test.

**The results replicate over three splits, and the cost of the design falls on pairs of columns.** Figure 3 shows the CoRTeC configurations on Adult at seeds 42, 43 and 44, each with a fresh split and a fresh release, beside the band that a real sample of the same size spans. The release spends its budget on single columns within cohorts and on the conditional rates a deployment names. An adaptive workload such as AIM's spends it on the pairs that matter most in the data, and the reference AIM fits pairs more closely than CoRTeC at every seed on Adult at $n$ = 1,000 and on NHANES at both sizes. On utility, the release reaches the reference AIM in five of the six dataset-size settings. We say that it reaches AIM's utility on a student when its mean is higher, or within 0.01 AUC with no consistent sign across the seeds. The exception is NHANES at $n$ = 300, where AIM's students score higher (0 of 3 seeds in CoRTeC's favour, p = 0.12 to 0.18).

On Adult, the fixed-rule release carries the seen conditionals more closely than the reference AIM at both sizes ($p < 0.01$ at $n$ = 300), while AIM's students score higher at $n$ = 1,000 (p = 0.07 to 0.08). With the auto-configured release, that utility gap closes at both sizes (p = 0.28 to 0.86). The two Adult releases differ in cohort size. The fixed rule forms twelve cohorts of 380 to 6,041 records, whereas the auto-configurator forms three cohorts of 4,434 to 13,345. A Laplace histogram has the same absolute noise whatever the count, so larger cohorts give smaller relative errors, while smaller cohorts give the named conditional rates. The conditional claim therefore belongs to the fixed rule, and the utility and single-column claims to the auto-configurator.

Appendix E.2 gives every seed and every paired test, and Appendix E.1 gives the other reference methods at the same budget.

## 5.5 The privacy architecture and the cost of a draw

**No private row reaches the model, and nothing is copied into a draw.** Five backbones decoded the same Adult release with the same prompts and settings (Appendix E.4). Single-column fidelity improves with model size and levels off at 14 billion parameters, while utility does not change with the backbone. The same Qwen3-14B, fine-tuned

with DP-SGD at the same budget, is further from the private table on both fidelity measures at both sizes (Table 3). Where the budget is spent matters more than which backbone is used. Membership inference (Appendix F) runs four attacks [11, 33, 34] on 3,000 candidates, half of them training rows and half held out, and each attack is validated on a positive control. The strongest advantage is at most 0.035 on every Adult configuration and 0.026 to 0.060 on NHANES, against a permitted 0.762. The distance-to-closest-record test finds no synthetic row that copies a training row, and no configuration that is closer to the training rows than to a held-out set (Appendix F). The served Gemini backbone can recite rows 2 to 25 of the public Adult file, but none of those rows appears in any CoRTeC draw (Appendix F.3). A 300-row Gemini draw costs 1.56 dollars at list price, and the same draw on Qwen3-14B takes about 50 minutes on one rented A40. The release itself takes seconds, and the maximum-entropy decoder runs on a CPU (Appendix G gives an indicative summary in percent).

## 6. Limitations

The fixed workload has a cost. Because the release spends its budget on the conditional rates a deployment names, it is less accurate on pairs of columns than an adaptive workload: the reference AIM fits pairs more closely on Adult at $n$ = 1,000 and on NHANES at both sizes. The reference AIM's students also score higher on NHANES at $n$ = 300, and higher than those of the fixed-rule release on Adult at $n$ = 1,000. On NHANES at $n$ = 300 and on bank marketing, AIM also fits the seen conditionals more closely. Our draws are at most 1,000 rows, so we have not measured utility at larger sizes. The gap to a real sample of the same size is largest on the medical dataset: 0.07 AUC at $n$ = 300. The language model's contribution depends on the column names, so an institution whose schema the model does not know should expect the decoder's result rather than the Gemini configuration's. Several results come from a single split: the backbone ladder, the anonymised and one-shot controls, the decoder at $\varepsilon = 0.5$ and 1, the bank dataset and the paper-protocol rows. The 8B and the anonymised 32B configurations have two draws each, and Gemini ran at $n$ = 300 only. The auto-configured release was decoded only without a model, so we have not measured what a model would add to it, and the Qwen3 backbones were not given the memorisation test. The reference AIM runs on CoRTeC's public bins, a conservative version of the PrivTree-binned AIM that Tab-PE's authors run [39]. We make no claim about high-order correlations, the axis on which Tab-PE's stress test separates methods [39]. Our rerun of the DP-LLMTGen procedure understates that method (Appendix E.6), so its published row is the one to use as the reference. Every real dataset here is a public benchmark. The anonymised control removes what the model knows about the schema, but not what it may know about the marginals. Finally, CoRTeC draws whose pool fell short of the requested size are scored as delivered (Appendix D), which costs them sampling error that the references do not pay.

## 7. Conclusion

For a regulated institution, the product is the release itself. The budget is spent once, on a file of counts with a workload fixed in advance, which anyone can inspect and decode at no further cost. Decoded without a language model, the release trains models close to a real sample of the same size, and after the selection step it carries the conditional rates it names more closely than such a sample does. The main argument for the design is its privacy architecture: the model never sees a row, every draw is post-processing, and the backbone can change without touching the guarantee. The measured membership advantage of the CoRTeC draws, 0.02 to 0.05, is a small fraction of the 0.762 the budget permits. CoRTeC is meant to sit beside the marginal methods, not to replace them. They suit a deployment that needs pairs of columns, and CoRTeC one that needs named conditional rates, a file it can inspect and decoding it can repeat. For a deployment, we recommend decoding with the maximum-entropy model and the selection step first, and adding a language model only where it knows the schema.

## Ethics Statement

This work uses public benchmark datasets and a national health survey released for research. No private institutional data was used. The membership attacks and memorisation tests were run on synthetic data we generated, and against a served commercial model using the public Adult file, which that model can partly reproduce. The method is meant to reduce the privacy risk of sharing tabular data. Its guarantee covers the release and its draws, not the model's pretraining corpus, and we state its limits where they arise.

## Reproducibility Statement

The repository (Calyie/cortec) holds the Apache-2.0 reference implementation with its tests, the research pipeline that produced every CoRTeC configuration, the paper and the frozen auto-configurations. Released statistics cannot be regenerated bit for bit, because the noise comes from a cryptographically secure source that ignores any seed. We therefore keep every stored release, and every draw reuses it by file. The reference-AIM wrapper, the maximum-entropy decoder, the decoder-with-selection and one-shot controls, the anonymisation of releases and the scorers are all in the repository. The released implementation decodes a release with no model through `cortec decode` (Private-PGM and the selection step). The synthetic draws, the per-draw score files, the membership-attack files and the stored releases of every configuration are deposited with the Zenodo record of this paper (10.5281/zenodo.22945315). Every number in this paper can be traced to a stored result file.

## AI-Use Statement

Language models appear in this work as the objects of study: they are the generators named in every table. Language-model assistants were also used to draft and edit the text and the code. Every experiment was designed, run and checked by the author, and every number was produced by the described pipeline from stored result files.

## Compute and Cost

The Qwen3 backbones and the DP fine-tuning baselines ran on one rented NVIDIA A40, using vLLM [45] for generation and Opacus [41] for DP-SGD. The reference AIM and MST fits and the maximum-entropy decoder ran on a CPU, and the Gemini configurations ran through Google's interface. The named and anonymised Gemini 3.6 Flash pairs cost 9.37 dollars in total, the memorisation test 0.33 dollars, and the one-shot control 2.52 dollars (156 calls). A 300-row CoRTeC draw takes 41 to 46 calls of 25 rows.

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## Appendix A. Privacy Analysis

*Proof of Theorem 1.* Let $D$ and $D'$ be neighbours that differ in one record $x$.

(i) *Forming the cohorts is free.* $\Pi$ is a function of public attribute domains, so $\Pi(x)$ is computed from $x$'s own attributes without looking at any other record. The partition does not depend on the data, and releasing it costs nothing.

(ii) *Within a cohort, sequential composition.* Fix a cohort $P$. Each released histogram is a counting query of L1 sensitivity 1, because $x$ contributes to exactly one bin of one attribute. Removing $x$ changes that histogram's L1 norm by 1 and leaves every other histogram unchanged. The Laplace mechanism at scale $1/\varepsilon_q$ makes each query $\varepsilon_q$-differentially private. Under the pooled block, the $q$ queries on $P$ compose sequentially to $q\,\varepsilon_q = \varepsilon_{\text{marg}}$. Under the class-conditional blocks, $P$ is split by $y$, so $x$ lies in exactly one of $P \cap \{y = 0\}$ and $P \cap \{y = 1\}$. It is touched by the class-balance query and by the $|A|$ histograms of its own block, and by nothing in the other block. That is again a chain of $q$ queries costing $q\,\varepsilon_q$. The two blocks do not overlap and compose in parallel. The pooled histogram is computed from released quantities only.

(iii) *Across cohorts, parallel composition.* The cohorts do not overlap. They are defined by a public rule or, under auto-configuration, by the released output of the charged selection, which Theorem 1 charges as $\varepsilon_{sel}$. The record $x$ lies in exactly one cohort, so it can affect only that cohort's queries. The cost across all cohorts is therefore $\varepsilon_{marg}$, however many cohorts there are.

(iv) *Within a conditional level, parallel composition.* The cells of a level partition $D$, so the level costs $\varepsilon_L$ however many cells it contains. Within a cell, the positive count and the cell size each have sensitivity 1 under add/remove adjacency. Both are noised with Lap($2/\varepsilon_L$), a scale that depends on nothing private, and since they touch the same records they compose sequentially to $\varepsilon_L$. The published rate $\tilde{k_c} / \max(\tilde{n_c}, n_{min})$, clipped to [0, 1], is post-processing of two released counts and the public floor. We do not noise the rate directly with a scale set by the private size $|c|$. Two Laplace densities with different scales have an unbounded likelihood ratio in one tail, so that mechanism would not be pure $\varepsilon$.

(v) *Across levels, sequential composition, and the cohort sizes.* The levels describe the same people and are not disjoint, so their budgets add: $|L|\ \varepsilon_L = \varepsilon_{cond}$. Each cohort size is a counting query of sensitivity 1 noised with Lap($1/\varepsilon_{count}$). The cohorts do not overlap, so all the sizes together cost $\varepsilon_{count}$, which composes sequentially with each cohort's other queries. Every $n_{min}$ decision compares a noised count with the public floor, and every cohort and cell of the public domains is queried whether or not it holds a record. Which groups appear in $R$ is therefore post-processing.

*Stage B is post-processing.* The row allocation reads released sizes. The per-bin counts a batch is asked for are apportioned from released histograms, and the counts still owed are the difference between released targets and generated rows. The prompt carries $R$ and those counts, and the frozen model reads only the prompt. The acceptance rule reads public domains. The inclusion weights, the raking, the refinement and the sub-bin redraw read $R$, the generated rows and fresh randomness. None of these steps increases the privacy loss, at any pool factor and for any number of draws. The maximum-entropy decoder reads only $R$ and is post-processing in the same way.

Adding the parts gives $\varepsilon_{count} + \varepsilon_{marg} + \varepsilon_{cond} = \varepsilon_{total}$. Under auto-configuration, the noised contingency tables of the candidate columns are counting queries of sensitivity 1 on the same records, and they compose sequentially to $\varepsilon_{sel}$. Everything computed from their noised counts is post-processing. The release that follows spends $\varepsilon_{release}$, and $\varepsilon_{sel} + \varepsilon_{release} = \varepsilon_{total}$. Stage C's $k$ rate queries are taken over $\max(|c|, n_{min})$, so each has sensitivity at most $1/n_{min}$. They act on disjoint cells with noise of public scale, and together they cost $\varepsilon_{cert}$. ∎

The floating-point attack on the Laplace mechanism [35] applies to every implementation we run, including ours, and the release's audit block lists it as an open gap. The empirical privacy of the private-pgm mechanisms we use as references has been audited and found close to their stated guarantee [16].

## Appendix B. Metrics, Floors and Tests

**Fidelity.** The 1-way total variation of a column is half the summed absolute difference between its synthetic and private histograms over the public bins. We average it over columns. The 2-way total variation is the same quantity over the joint histogram of each pair of columns, averaged over pairs. Both are measured against the full private training table. Conditional total variation is the mean absolute difference between $P(y = 1 \mid g)$ in the synthetic table and in the private table, over a family of groups $g$. We use two families: the cohort bands of the stratification rule ("seen", the groups every release describes), and groups built from columns that share nothing with the conditioning ("held-out").

**Utility.** We measure train-on-synthetic, test-on-real AUC with three students: logistic regression (balanced, 2,000 iterations, standardised inputs), a random forest (300 trees, balanced) and gradient boosting (scikit-learn's histogram implementation). Each is trained on the synthetic table and scored on the real test split of the same seed. We report the three students separately, because a result can change sign between a linear and a tree student.

**References in every table.** The real sample is a fresh draw of $n$ rows from the training split, drawn once per table at that table's $n$, so its value varies between tables by design. The permuted target is the same rows with the target column shuffled, which keeps every marginal and removes every link between the features and the target. The ceiling trains the students on a real sample of 4,000 training rows, or on the whole training split where it holds fewer (NHANES, 2,999 rows). Its fidelity cells are that sample's distance from the full training table: the sampling error at 4,000 rows, and 0 where the sample is the whole split. The two floors separate on every conditional and utility measure but not on the marginal ones, which is why no marginal measure is read on its own.

**Repetition and tests.** Every cell is the mean over three draws from one release, with the sample standard deviation. The replication draws a fresh split and a fresh release at seeds 43 and 44. For each pair of conditions it reports the mean paired difference over the three seeds, the sign count and a two-sided paired t-test (scipy). With three pairs the test has little power, so a difference is read as replicated when its sign is the same at every seed, and its p-value is reported beside it.

**The bin convention.** The evaluator's intervals are closed on the right and the release's on the left, so an integer that falls exactly on an edge is counted in different bins by the two. On Adult this changes 1-way error by 0.003 and changes no ordering.

## Appendix C. Datasets, Preprocessing and the Anonymised Schema

**Adult.** We use the 32,561 rows of the UCI training file and keep "?" as a category. There are 6 numerical columns (age, final weight, education number, capital gain, capital loss, hours per week) and 8 categorical ones, and the target is income over 50K. The public bins follow the edges declared in the schema. The cohorts come from the schema's own rule over education and hours per week, and the conditional levels are the first and the fourth of the declared hierarchy. The auto-configured Adult release (Section 5, Appendix D) takes its cohorts and levels from the auto-configurator instead.

**NHANES 2017-2018.** We join the demographic, glycohaemoglobin, body-measures and blood-pressure files on the respondent identifier and keep adults aged 18 to 80. There are 5 numerical columns (age, BMI, waist, systolic and diastolic blood pressure) and 4 categorical ones (sex, race and ethnicity, education, income bracket), and the target is HbA1c at or above 6.5 %. The bin edges are public clinical knowledge: WHO BMI categories and ACC/AHA blood-pressure stages. The release is auto-configured. The auto-configurator's charged column ranking chose three age cohorts and two conditional levels over age, diastolic blood pressure, and race and ethnicity.

**Bank marketing.** We use the UCI file of 45,211 rows and 13 of its 16 input columns. Five are numerical (age, balance, call duration, campaign contacts, days since the previous campaign) and eight categorical (job, marital status, education, default, housing loan, personal loan, contact type, previous outcome). The day, month and previous-contact-count columns are not used. The target is a term-deposit subscription, the split is 80/20 at seed 42, and the release is auto-configured in the same way as NHANES.

**The anonymised schema.** A fixed public rule replaces every column name, category label, band label and the dataset description with a neutral token. Numerical columns become n1 to n6 in schema order, categorical columns k1 to k8, and the target y with classes A and B. Each categorical column's sorted categories become k3_v01, k3_v02 and so on, and numerical band labels become n3_b1, n3_b2 and so on. Numeric values, public bounds, bins, the cohort rule, the conditional levels and the held-out families are unchanged. A release of Adult therefore maps one to one onto a release of the anonymised schema, and the model sees the same prompt templates with the meaning removed. The draws are mapped back before scoring, so the scorer is the same.

## Appendix D. Configuration, the Prompt and the Baselines

**CoRTeC settings.** We use $\varepsilon = 2$ (0.5 and 1 where stated), a conditional share $\alpha = 0.2$, a count share $\gamma = 0.02$ and $n_{\min} = 150$. Each call asks for 25 rows, with the counts stated per outcome class. The pool factor is 3 (2 on NHANES), the selection step uses the sub-bin rule, and one cohort worker runs at a time, with seed 42 for the generator and the selection. The Qwen3 backbones ran through vLLM [45] with each model's default sampling, and the Gemini backbone ran with reasoning enabled through Google's interface. A CoRTeC draw is scored as delivered. Where the pool fell short of the requested size, the draw holds fewer than $n$ rows. On the Qwen3 configurations, this means 276 to 300 rows at $n = 300$ and 949 to 1,000 at $n = 1{,}000$. On the Qwen2.5-7B configuration the ranges are 257 to 279 and 807 to 864, and on the Gemini and bank marketing configurations every draw is within 1 % of $n$. The real-sample and permuted references in every table are drawn at the full $n$. Fewer rows add sampling error to a draw's own fidelity measures, so the shortfall works against CoRTeC and against no other method. A call whose output does not parse is retried, and the stored manifests record the retry and parse rates for each backbone. Qwen3-14B produced no parse failure in about 1,500 calls. Qwen3-8B writes the prompt's range labels into numerical columns when a quota is small. The quantised 32B model fails about three NHANES calls in four on one cohort, and it completes when resumed.

**The prompt.** The system message and the cohort template are fixed and fingerprinted in the reference implementation. The system message asks the model to reproduce the distributions and relationships the statistics describe "even if this contradicts your expectations about how these variables usually relate", to treat the statistics as describing this specific population, and to output only CSV rows. The cohort template states the subgroup, the released numerical histograms, the released categorical shares, the outcome rate, and the conditional outcome table, which it calls the most important part of the prompt. It then gives the exact counts the batch must carry for each bin, category and outcome, the output format, and four rules: values inside their ranges, the target as one of its two labels, no repeated rows, and nothing but the header and the rows. In a cohort with class blocks, the numerical and categorical blocks are given once for each outcome class. The full text is in the reference implementation's template file and in the deployment guide.

**The integer rule.** Whether a numerical column holds integers is decided from the public bin edges and bounds, which must all be whole numbers, together with the majority of the pool's values. A rule that looks at every value instead lets a single model-written "45.0" or "37.5" turn the column into real values. The sub-bin redraw then produces fractional ages, hours and capital values, which an evaluator comparing exact values treats as far from the data. The anonymised Qwen3-14B draws, selected under that rule during development, scored 0.117 on single columns before flooring and 0.065 after. Every CoRTeC draw in this paper is scored after its integer columns are floored, and the released implementation carries the majority rule with a regression test. The Tab-PE and DP-2Stage draws are scored as their methods deliver them, with fractional values in integer columns. Flooring those columns would lower their 1-way and 2-way distances by at most 0.011 and 0.017 on the draws we measured, so no ordering depends on it. Two anonymised Qwen3-32B draws have 25 and 24 empty hours-per-week cells, which the scorer drops from that column's histogram.

**Reference AIM and MST.** We use private-pgm (mbi 1.1) at the authors' defaults: an 80 MB maximum model size, a 2-way workload, 1,000 mirror-descent iterations, the exponential mechanism for AIM's selection, $\delta = 10^{-9}$, and the corrected sampler for both. During development we also ran the smartnoise-synth implementations of AIM and MST at their library defaults. They carry the sampler defect described below, and their students score 0.15 to 0.17 AUC below the reference implementation's on Adult at $n = 300$. No number from them appears in this paper. Every AIM and MST number here comes from the authors' private-pgm.

The wrapper is invoked as `pgm_baselines.py --train <split> --dataset <name> --epsilon 2 --n-out <n> --draws 3 --seed 42 --methods aim mst --max-model-size 80 --degree 2 --max-iters 1000`. For the reference AIM rows of Table 3 and of the replication, `PGM_ORACLE=stable` and `PGM_CONSISTENCY_GATE=0.08` are set in the environment, with three draws per seed under the stable oracle so that the three seeds are like for like. The reference MST rows and the $\varepsilon = 0.5$ and 1 rows of Appendix E.7 are five draws (`--draws 5`) from the wrapper's runs under the library's default oracle, which is why the caption of Table 3 counts five draws for MST. The wrapper is in the repository with the decoder, the scorers and the anonymisation map.

Under mbi's default message-passing oracle, the fit raised "probabilities contain NaN" inside mirror descent on the seed-43 and seed-44 splits of both datasets, and on seeds 45 to 47, 53, 54 and 60 to 63 in a sweep. The library's fallback, a halved step, returned near-uniform models. On seed 43, NHANES, $n = 300$, such a model gave a 1-way total variation of 0.182, students at 0.50 and a diabetes rate of 43 % against 14 %. None of those fits is reported. With the log-space oracle (`marginal_oracles.message_passing_stable`) the same seeds converge at the first attempt. On the seed-42 Adult split, the stable refit matches the default-oracle fit to within 0.002 on single columns and pairs (0.029 and 0.072 against 0.031 and 0.074 at $n = 1{,}000$) and within 0.001 AUC on the students (0.854, 0.888 and 0.883 against 0.853, 0.887 and 0.883). The consistency check is the mean total variation between the fitted marginals and the noisy measurements they were fitted to, which reads released values only. The library's threshold is 0.15. We set it to 0.08, because the first-attempt fits on every seed and size measure between 0.005 and 0.036, so a threshold of about twice the largest accepted value rejects a fallback fit and accepts every legitimate one. Every reported fit passed at its first attempt.

The corrected sampler fixes a defect in mbi 1.1's `synthetic_data`. That function reads each child column's conditional table in the model's attribute order, not in the order in which the parents were sampled. Where the two orders differ, the joint structure of some columns is scrambled while every 1-way marginal survives. The wrapper samples each column from its conditional with the axes aligned, and the sampled conditionals then match the fitted model's to within 0.01.

**The maximum-entropy decoder.** Private-PGM's estimator is given exactly the released cohort sizes, class balances, histograms and conditional table of CoRTeC's release as its measurements, with no further noise and no further query, and it is sampled at the requested $n$.

**The decoder with the selection step.** On each of the three splits, the decoder of that split's release is sampled at three times $n$, giving three pools per size. Each pool is passed through Algorithm 2 with the sub-bin rule, using the same seeds as the CoRTeC configurations, and the integer columns are floored. The selection fell one to three rows short of $n$ in six of the eighteen draws. This is post-processing of the release, with no privacy cost, and it runs on a CPU.

**The auto-configured Adult release.** On each split we ran the released implementation's Stage A (`release_statistics` with the auto-configurator). On the seed-42 and seed-44 splits it chose three age cohorts and a hierarchy of relationship, then relationship by marital status. On the seed-43 split it chose education-number cohorts and a hierarchy of relationship, then relationship by native country. The budget went 0.05 to the hierarchy selection, 0.05 plus the gate charge to the published counts, a fifth of the remainder to the conditional cells and the rest to the marginals. Each split used 105 queries, accounted $\varepsilon = 2.000$ and sealed the ledger. The release was decoded by `cortec decode` (the maximum-entropy fit, a pool of three times $n$ and the selection step) with seeds 42 to 44, and the fit's consistency with the release was 0.004. No language model was run on it.

**The one-shot control.** This uses the research pipeline's header-only prompt: the dataset's one-line description, the column names in order, the two labels of the target and a request for 25 realistic rows per call. It uses no release and no private data. The model is Gemini 3.6 Flash with reasoning at its default, as in the Gemini configurations, with twelve calls per 300-row draw and forty per 1,000-row draw. Integer columns are floored and the draws are scored as delivered. The draws' positive rate is 36 to 38 %, against the data's 24 %, and about 70 % of their rows are verbatim copies of the public file's first 25 rows (Appendix F.3).

**DP-2Stage.** We ran the authors' released code: GPT-2, full fine-tuning, DP-Adam, clipping 1, $\delta = 10^{-5}$, loss weight 0.65, five pseudo-data epochs and ten private epochs, and temperature 0.7 with rejection sampling. It ran on our seed-42 split at $\varepsilon = 2$ and, under the authors' protocol, on their own split at $\varepsilon = 1$.

**DP fine-tuning of the same backbones.** We applied DP-LLMTGen's procedure to Qwen3-14B, Qwen2.5-7B and Llama-2 7B. Stage 1 trains for five epochs on random tables drawn from the public names, categories and ranges, at a learning rate of $10^{-4}$. Stage 2 trains for two epochs of DP-SGD (Opacus [41]) on the private rows, with LoRA [20] of rank 8 on the attention projections (10.5 million trainable parameters on the 14B), a learning rate of $5 \times 10^{-4}$, batch size 32, clipping 1, the weighted cross-entropy with $\alpha = 0.65$, and $\delta = 10^{-5}$. It spent $\varepsilon = 1.994$ of 2. Sampling at temperature 0.7 gave valid rows on 99.7 % of attempts. We omit the original's numerical-understanding loss, because its coefficients are not given.

**Tab-PE.** We used the authors' DPSDA code and their Adult example: a mutation rate of 0.5 decaying polynomially to 0.01 with $\gamma = 0.2$, the composite population with sampling then ranking, the L2 nearest-neighbour histogram, $\delta = 1/(n \ln n)$, 29 to 30 iterations, and a noise multiplier of 11.3 at $\varepsilon = 2$ on our split. Populations were 1,000 rows (600 on NHANES) and, under the authors' protocol, 2,000 rows on their 70/15/15 split with 30 iterations.

## Appendix E. Full Tables

**E.1 NHANES at $\varepsilon = 2$, seed 42, three draws.** Lower is better in the first four columns and higher in the last three.

| condition, $n = 300$ | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | cond. held-out | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *all 2,999 training rows (utility ceiling)* | *0.000* | *0.000* | *0.000* | *0.000* | *0.797* | *0.763* | *0.747* |
| *real sample (floor)* | *0.034* | *0.081* | *0.015* | *0.036* | *0.773* | *0.728* | *0.716* |
| *permuted target* | *0.043* | *0.093* | *0.047* | *0.060* | *0.493* | *0.514* | *0.515* |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B | 0.029 | 0.158 | 0.036 | 0.075 | 0.678 | 0.657 | 0.645 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-32B (AWQ) | 0.047 | 0.157 | 0.036 | 0.046 | 0.681 | 0.677 | 0.657 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-8B | 0.042 | 0.181 | 0.017 | 0.050 | 0.651 | 0.646 | 0.655 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 0.042 | 0.117 | 0.025 | 0.041 | 0.705 | 0.694 | 0.691 |
| reference AIM | 0.042 | 0.100 | 0.017 | 0.044 | 0.747 | 0.721 | 0.710 |
| reference MST (5 draws) | 0.045 | 0.110 | 0.026 | 0.060 | 0.709 | 0.668 | 0.642 |

| condition, $n$ = 300 | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | cond. held-out | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| DP-2Stage, GPT-2 | 0.175 | 0.295 | 0.117 | 0.115 | 0.527 | 0.537 | 0.553 |
| DP fine-tuned Qwen3-14B | 0.116 | 0.205 | 0.074 | 0.077 | 0.575 | 0.544 | 0.527 |
| Tab-PE (600-row population) | 0.064 | 0.151 | 0.030 | 0.053 | 0.739 | 0.729 | 0.724 |
| **condition, $n$ = 1,000** | | | | | | | |
| *real sample (floor)* | *0.016* | *0.039* | *0.008* | *0.016* | *0.783* | *0.752* | *0.744* |
| *permuted target* | *0.017* | *0.044* | *0.039* | *0.047* | *0.516* | *0.484* | *0.470* |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B | 0.027 | 0.150 | 0.031 | 0.069 | 0.696 | 0.648 | 0.639 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-32B (AWQ) | 0.036 | 0.123 | 0.023 | 0.031 | 0.748 | 0.727 | 0.701 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-8B | 0.034 | 0.156 | 0.023 | 0.040 | 0.748 | 0.688 | 0.671 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 0.031 | 0.088 | 0.022 | 0.029 | 0.758 | 0.720 | 0.686 |
| reference AIM | 0.029 | 0.070 | 0.027 | 0.032 | 0.752 | 0.714 | 0.660 |
| reference MST (5 draws) | 0.028 | 0.075 | 0.016 | 0.048 | 0.727 | 0.692 | 0.679 |
| DP-2Stage, GPT-2 | 0.169 | 0.284 | 0.120 | 0.110 | 0.538 | 0.520 | 0.512 |
| DP fine-tuned Qwen3-14B | 0.117 | 0.195 | 0.089 | 0.078 | 0.571 | 0.516 | 0.501 |
| Tab-PE (1,000-row population) | 0.060 | 0.132 | 0.027 | 0.041 | 0.743 | 0.721 | 0.716 |

**E.2 Replication: means over seeds, with the standard deviation across seeds, and the paired differences.** The real-sample row is each split's own sample of $n$ training rows, averaged over the three splits. It is the band in Figure 3. Each seed's value is the mean of three draws. p is a two-sided paired t-test over the three seeds, and the sign count gives how many seeds have a positive and a negative difference. The decoder-with-selection rows are the fixed-rule release decoded with no model and passed through the selection step on each split. The auto-configured rows are the release the auto-configurator derives on Adult, decoded the same way (Section 5.1). Their conditional cells are not comparable and are left out. The evaluator's seen bands are the fixed rule's cohorts, which that release does not condition on, and two of the three held-out families (relationship and native country) are columns it does condition on. On the one family that shares no column with its conditioning, workclass by race, its conditional error is 0.043 against the reference AIM's 0.061 at $n$ = 300 and 0.020 against 0.036 at $n$ = 1,000, with 0 of 3 seeds in AIM's favour at both sizes. The decoder reads 0.061 and 0.043.

| Adult, $n$ = 300 | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | cond. held-out | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *real sample (floor)* | *0.044 ± 0.001* | *0.109 ± 0.001* | *0.066 ± 0.014* | *0.043 ± 0.007* | *0.834 ± 0.005* | *0.869 ± 0.005* | *0.841 ± 0.003* |
| CoRTeC Qwen3-14B | 0.054 ± 0.008 | 0.146 ± 0.006 | 0.035 ± 0.007 | 0.048 ± 0.002 | 0.815 ± 0.009 | 0.860 ± 0.002 | 0.835 ± 0.002 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 0.058 ± 0.002 | 0.145 ± 0.003 | 0.073 ± 0.008 | 0.049 ± 0.003 | 0.818 ± 0.000 | 0.857 ± 0.001 | 0.847 ± 0.002 |
| decoder with selection | 0.035 ± 0.003 | 0.120 ± 0.002 | 0.017 ± 0.002 | 0.043 ± 0.004 | 0.822 ± 0.002 | 0.861 ± 0.004 | 0.853 ± 0.008 |
| reference AIM | 0.052 ± 0.004 | 0.120 ± 0.003 | 0.061 ± 0.006 | 0.048 ± 0.001 | 0.832 ± 0.011 | 0.866 ± 0.003 | 0.839 ± 0.006 |
| auto-configured, no model, with selection | 0.020 ± 0.001 | 0.109 ± 0.001 | n/a | n/a | 0.830 ± 0.004 | 0.870 ± 0.006 | 0.859 ± 0.002 |
| CoRTeC minus decoder | −0.004 [1+/2−] 0.47 | +0.001 [2+/1−] 0.88 | −0.038 [0+/3−] 0.04 | −0.001 [1+/2−] 0.44 | −0.003 [1+/2−] 0.63 | +0.003 [3+/0−] 0.12 | −0.012 [0+/3−] 0.01 |
| CoRTeC minus AIM | +0.002 [2+/1−] 0.80 | +0.027 [3+/0−] 0.03 | −0.027 [0+/3−] <0.01 | −0.000 [2+/1−] 0.86 | −0.017 [1+/2−] 0.28 | −0.006 [0+/3−] 0.02 | −0.004 [1+/2−] 0.42 |
| decoder minus AIM | +0.006 [3+/0−] 0.18 | +0.026 [3+/0−] 0.01 | +0.012 [3+/0−] 0.27 | +0.001 [2+/1−] 0.81 | −0.014 [0+/3−] 0.18 | −0.009 [0+/3−] 0.05 | +0.008 [3+/0−] 0.13 |
| selection minus decoder | −0.023 [0+/3−] 0.01 | −0.025 [0+/3−] 0.01 | −0.056 [0+/3−] 0.01 | −0.006 [0+/3−] 0.20 | +0.003 [3+/0−] 0.17 | +0.005 [3+/0−] 0.19 | +0.006 [3+/0−] 0.31 |
| selection minus AIM | −0.017 [0+/3−] 0.03 | +0.001 [2+/1−] 0.76 | −0.045 [0+/3−] <0.01 | −0.005 [1+/2−] 0.23 | −0.010 [0+/3−] 0.20 | −0.004 [0+/3−] 0.01 | +0.014 [3+/0−] 0.01 |
| auto-configured minus AIM | −0.032 [0+/3−] 0.01 | −0.011 [0+/3−] 0.05 | n/a | n/a | −0.002 [2+/1−] 0.86 | +0.004 [2+/1−] 0.28 | +0.020 [3+/0−] 0.03 |
| auto-configured minus selection | −0.015 [0+/3−] 0.01 | −0.012 [0+/3−] 0.02 | n/a | n/a | +0.009 [3+/0−] 0.13 | +0.008 [3+/0−] 0.08 | +0.006 [2+/1−] 0.28 |

| Adult, $n$ = 1,000 | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | cond. held-out | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *real sample (floor)* | *0.024 ± 0.002* | *0.061 ± 0.002* | *0.035 ± 0.006* | *0.025 ± 0.005* | *0.849 ± 0.006* | *0.890 ± 0.005* | *0.885 ± 0.005* |

| Adult, $n$ = 1,000 | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | cond. held-out | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| CoRTeC Qwen3-14B | 0.039 ± 0.004 | 0.112 ± 0.005 | 0.027 ± 0.006 | 0.033 ± 0.003 | 0.829 ± 0.002 | 0.863 ± 0.004 | 0.860 ± 0.003 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 0.041 ± 0.001 | 0.107 ± 0.001 | 0.033 ± 0.003 | 0.042 ± 0.003 | 0.825 ± 0.001 | 0.868 ± 0.003 | 0.863 ± 0.003 |
| decoder with selection | 0.027 ± 0.001 | 0.090 ± 0.001 | 0.007 ± 0.001 | 0.033 ± 0.004 | 0.832 ± 0.004 | 0.871 ± 0.003 | 0.871 ± 0.002 |
| reference AIM | 0.031 ± 0.001 | 0.074 ± 0.001 | 0.034 ± 0.005 | 0.031 ± 0.001 | 0.847 ± 0.007 | 0.882 ± 0.005 | 0.876 ± 0.006 |
| auto-configured, no model, with selection | 0.016 ± 0.000 | 0.082 ± 0.002 | n/a | n/a | 0.840 ± 0.006 | 0.879 ± 0.009 | 0.881 ± 0.006 |
| CoRTeC minus decoder | −0.002 [1+/2−] 0.52 | +0.005 [3+/0−] 0.27 | −0.005 [1+/2−] 0.38 | −0.009 [0+/3−] 0.07 | +0.004 [3+/0−] 0.13 | −0.005 [0+/3−] 0.20 | −0.002 [0+/3−] 0.25 |
| CoRTeC minus AIM | +0.009 [3+/0−] 0.04 | +0.038 [3+/0−] <0.01 | −0.007 [0+/3−] 0.09 | +0.002 [2+/1−] 0.36 | −0.017 [0+/3−] 0.07 | −0.019 [0+/3−] 0.07 | −0.016 [0+/3−] 0.08 |
| decoder minus AIM | +0.011 [3+/0−] <0.01 | +0.033 [3+/0−] <0.01 | −0.002 [1+/2−] 0.69 | +0.011 [3+/0−] 0.03 | −0.021 [0+/3−] 0.03 | −0.014 [0+/3−] 0.04 | −0.014 [0+/3−] 0.07 |
| selection minus decoder | −0.014 [0+/3−] <0.01 | −0.017 [0+/3−] <0.01 | −0.025 [0+/3−] <0.01 | −0.009 [0+/3−] 0.03 | +0.007 [3+/0−] 0.05 | +0.003 [3+/0−] 0.01 | +0.009 [3+/0−] 0.07 |
| selection minus AIM | −0.003 [0+/3−] 0.05 | +0.017 [3+/0−] <0.01 | −0.027 [0+/3−] 0.02 | +0.002 [2+/1−] 0.60 | −0.014 [0+/3−] 0.02 | −0.011 [0+/3−] 0.06 | −0.005 [0+/3−] 0.16 |
| auto-configured minus AIM | −0.015 [0+/3−] <0.01 | +0.009 [3+/0−] <0.01 | n/a | n/a | −0.007 [1+/2−] 0.36 | −0.003 [1+/2−] 0.56 | +0.004 [3+/0−] 0.35 |
| auto-configured minus selection | −0.011 [0+/3−] <0.01 | −0.008 [0+/3−] 0.03 | n/a | n/a | +0.008 [3+/0−] 0.23 | +0.007 [3+/0−] 0.17 | +0.009 [3+/0−] 0.11 |

| NHANES, $n$ = 300 | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | cond. held-out | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *real sample (floor)* | *0.037 ± 0.006* | *0.086 ± 0.006* | *0.021 ± 0.007* | *0.032 ± 0.004* | *0.766 ± 0.009* | *0.740 ± 0.010* | *0.721 ± 0.006* |
| CoRTeC Qwen3-14B | 0.044 ± 0.013 | 0.161 ± 0.011 | 0.021 ± 0.013 | 0.057 ± 0.020 | 0.710 ± 0.033 | 0.689 ± 0.028 | 0.667 ± 0.029 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 0.041 ± 0.001 | 0.117 ± 0.001 | 0.024 ± 0.001 | 0.040 ± 0.002 | 0.717 ± 0.016 | 0.713 ± 0.023 | 0.705 ± 0.015 |
| reference AIM | 0.042 ± 0.001 | 0.103 ± 0.003 | 0.019 ± 0.003 | 0.041 ± 0.007 | 0.752 ± 0.005 | 0.725 ± 0.004 | 0.706 ± 0.005 |
| CoRTeC minus decoder | +0.003 [2+/1−] 0.78 | +0.044 [3+/0−] 0.02 | −0.002 [1+/2−] 0.77 | +0.017 [2+/1−] 0.26 | −0.007 [1+/2−] 0.75 | −0.024 [1+/2−] 0.21 | −0.037 [0+/3−] 0.17 |
| CoRTeC minus AIM | +0.001 [2+/1−] 0.87 | +0.058 [3+/0−] 0.02 | +0.002 [1+/2−] 0.83 | +0.016 [2+/1−] 0.37 | −0.042 [0+/3−] 0.12 | −0.036 [0+/3−] 0.13 | −0.039 [0+/3−] 0.18 |
| decoder minus AIM | −0.001 [1+/2−] 0.22 | +0.014 [3+/0−] 0.01 | +0.004 [3+/0−] 0.15 | −0.001 [1+/2−] 0.73 | −0.035 [0+/3−] 0.06 | −0.012 [1+/2−] 0.45 | −0.002 [2+/1−] 0.87 |

| NHANES, $n$ = 1,000 | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | cond. held-out | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *real sample (floor)* | *0.018 ± 0.002* | *0.040 ± 0.001* | *0.011 ± 0.003* | *0.015 ± 0.001* | *0.785 ± 0.006* | *0.758 ± 0.006* | *0.749 ± 0.005* |
| CoRTeC Qwen3-14B | 0.040 ± 0.013 | 0.151 ± 0.008 | 0.022 ± 0.008 | 0.054 ± 0.016 | 0.732 ± 0.031 | 0.686 ± 0.037 | 0.669 ± 0.034 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 0.031 ± 0.002 | 0.087 ± 0.002 | 0.018 ± 0.003 | 0.026 ± 0.003 | 0.769 ± 0.011 | 0.745 ± 0.023 | 0.722 ± 0.032 |
| reference AIM | 0.030 ± 0.002 | 0.071 ± 0.001 | 0.022 ± 0.007 | 0.035 ± 0.016 | 0.734 ± 0.027 | 0.701 ± 0.033 | 0.676 ± 0.022 |
| CoRTeC minus decoder | +0.009 [2+/1−] 0.34 | +0.064 [3+/0−] <0.01 | +0.004 [3+/0−] 0.25 | +0.028 [3+/0−] 0.09 | −0.037 [0+/3−] 0.10 | −0.059 [0+/3−] 0.06 | −0.053 [0+/3−] 0.08 |
| CoRTeC minus AIM | +0.009 [2+/1−] 0.33 | +0.080 [3+/0−] <0.01 | −0.000 [2+/1−] 0.96 | +0.018 [3+/0−] 0.21 | −0.002 [2+/1−] 0.96 | −0.015 [1+/2−] 0.73 | −0.007 [1+/2−] 0.81 |
| decoder minus AIM | +0.000 [2+/1−] 0.85 | +0.016 [3+/0−] 0.01 | −0.004 [1+/2−] 0.34 | −0.010 [1+/2−] 0.47 | +0.035 [3+/0−] 0.24 | +0.044 [3+/0−] 0.21 | +0.046 [3+/0−] 0.07 |

**E.3 Per-pair reading.** For every pair of columns we compared the pairwise total variation of the model's draws and of the decoder's draws against the private table, on the seed-42 split. On Adult, the model's error is below the decoder's on the pairs it recognises as logically linked. For education with education number, the decoder reads 0.26 to 0.40 and the model 0.08 to 0.32 across backbones and sizes. For marital status with relationship, the model reads 0.08 to 0.30 against the decoder's 0.33 to 0.40, and for relationship with sex 0.03 to 0.19 against 0.22 to 0.26. The same holds for workclass with occupation. On the pairs the release describes only through the cohorts, the model's error is at or above the decoder's. On bank marketing, the model repairs days since contact with the previous

outcome. It raises the error on four nearly independent pairs on which the decoder matches the real sample: education with contact, contact with the previous outcome, marital status with education, and loan with contact. The same pattern appears at both sizes and on every backbone.

**E.4 The backbone ladder.** One Adult release and one NHANES release, decoded with the same prompts, settings and evaluator, with only the model changed. Each cell gives single-column and pairwise total variation, then the three students.

| backbone | Adult $n$ = 300 | utility | Adult $n$ = 1,000 | utility | NHANES $n$ = 300 | utility | NHANES $n$ = 1,000 | utility |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Qwen2.5-7B | 0.110 / 0.220 | 0.81 / 0.85 / 0.83 | 0.089 / 0.178 | 0.81 / 0.86 / 0.85 | 0.045 / 0.160 | 0.64 / 0.64 / 0.61 | 0.039 / 0.145 | 0.66 / 0.64 / 0.62 |
| Qwen3-8B | 0.068 / 0.164 | 0.80 / 0.85 / 0.82 | 0.048 / 0.124 (2 draws) | 0.82 / 0.85 / 0.84 | 0.042 / 0.181 | 0.65 / 0.65 / 0.66 | 0.034 / 0.156 | 0.75 / 0.69 / 0.67 |
| Qwen3-14B | 0.046 / 0.139 | 0.81 / 0.86 / 0.83 | 0.036 / 0.108 | 0.83 / 0.86 / 0.86 | 0.029 / 0.158 | 0.68 / 0.66 / 0.65 | 0.027 / 0.150 | 0.70 / 0.65 / 0.64 |
| Qwen3-32B (AWQ) | 0.049 / 0.138 | 0.82 / 0.86 / 0.84 | 0.035 / 0.103 | 0.82 / 0.86 / 0.85 | 0.047 / 0.157 | 0.68 / 0.68 / 0.66 | 0.036 / 0.123 | 0.75 / 0.73 / 0.70 |
| Gemini 3.6 Flash | 0.027 / 0.110 | 0.81 / 0.86 / 0.84 | not run | | not run | | not run | |
| *maximum-entropy decoder* | *0.058 / 0.146* | *0.82 / 0.86 / 0.85* | *0.041 / 0.106* | *0.83 / 0.87 / 0.86* | *0.042 / 0.117* | *0.71 / 0.69 / 0.69* | *0.031 / 0.088* | *0.76 / 0.72 / 0.69* |
| *reference AIM* | *0.056 / 0.122* | *0.85 / 0.87 / 0.85* | *0.029 / 0.072* | *0.85 / 0.89 / 0.88* | *0.042 / 0.100* | *0.75 / 0.72 / 0.71* | *0.029 / 0.070* | *0.75 / 0.71 / 0.66* |
| *real sample* | *0.043 / 0.107* | *0.83 / 0.87 / 0.84* | *0.026 / 0.061* | *0.86 / 0.89 / 0.88* | *0.034 / 0.081* | *0.77 / 0.73 / 0.72* | *0.016 / 0.039* | *0.78 / 0.75 / 0.74* |

**E.5 Bank marketing at ε = 2, one split, three draws.** The held-out conditional family is not defined on this schema.

| condition | $n$ | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *real sample* | 300 | *0.025* | *0.052* | *0.014* | *0.833* | *0.849* | *0.833* |
| *permuted target* | 300 | *0.027* | *0.056* | *0.096* | *0.415* | *0.467* | *0.463* |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B | 300 | 0.040 | 0.112 | 0.013 | 0.802 | 0.799 | 0.781 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 300 | 0.026 | 0.066 | 0.036 | 0.824 | 0.802 | 0.802 |
| reference AIM | 300 | 0.034 | 0.068 | 0.021 | 0.815 | 0.805 | 0.772 |
| *real sample* | 1,000 | *0.014* | *0.028* | *0.008* | *0.862* | *0.871* | *0.860* |
| *permuted target* | 1,000 | *0.013* | *0.031* | *0.089* | *0.503* | *0.483* | *0.485* |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B | 1,000 | 0.034 | 0.101 | 0.011 | 0.810 | 0.784 | 0.759 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 1,000 | 0.013 | 0.043 | 0.013 | 0.837 | 0.848 | 0.837 |
| reference AIM | 1,000 | 0.024 | 0.049 | 0.006 | 0.839 | 0.824 | 0.805 |
| *real sample of 4,000 rows (utility ceiling)* | | *0.007* | *0.014* | *0.005* | *0.869* | *0.890* | *0.891* |

**E.6 The three papers' own protocols on Adult, ε = 1, one split.** The published rows are the papers' own. Our rows are scored by our implementation of each paper's metrics. Under the DP-LLMTGen protocol, the distance columns are on our scorer's scale, which reads the training set itself at 0.009 against the paper's 0.004, so only the utility columns can be compared across the two sources. Under the Tab-PE protocol, the embedding-space precision and recall depend on the implementation and are left out. Rows marked three seeds are means over the three Tab-PE splits.

| protocol and method | fidelity (the paper's measure) ↓ | utility (the paper's measure) ↑ |
|---|---|---|
| **DP-LLMTGen protocol** (1-way, 2-way TVD against the test split; XGBoost ACC, AUC) | | |
| DP-LLMTGen, Llama-2 7B (published) | 0.038, 0.068 | 0.831, 0.879 |
| RAP++ (published) | 0.054, 0.099 | 0.803, 0.807 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B (ours) | 0.060, 0.121 | 0.831, 0.881 |
| maximum-entropy decoder (ours) | 0.034, 0.089 | 0.818, 0.888 |
| reference AIM (ours) | 0.018, 0.046 | 0.850, 0.902 |

| protocol and method | fidelity (the paper's measure) ↓ | utility (the paper's measure) ↑ |
|---|---|---|
| reference MST (ours) | 0.018, 0.061 | 0.813, 0.836 |
| DP fine-tuned Llama-2 7B, our run of the procedure | 0.103, 0.177 | 0.795, 0.841 |
| **DP-2Stage protocol** (their split and metric suite; Pair, HIST, CorAcc in %; F1, AUC in %) | | |
| real data (published) | 97.5, 99.1, 97.3 | 69.9, 91.7 |
| AIM (published) | 77.1, 88.4, 86.4 | 59.6, 86.8 |
| DP-2Stage-O (published) | 72.3, 88.5, 55.4 | 30.4, 61.6 |
| DP-2Stage-O, our run of their code | 63.0, 84.7, 56.4 | 26.2, 59.9 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B (ours) | 70.8, 84.6, 63.6 | 61.8, 87.1 |
| maximum-entropy decoder (ours) | 74.3, 87.6, 69.8 | 62.8, 87.1 |
| reference AIM (ours) | 93.1, 97.2, 83.1 | 62.9, 87.7 |
| reference MST (ours) | 92.6, 97.2, 74.2 | 51.5, 84.0 |
| **Tab-PE protocol** (1-WD, 2-WD against the private table; TabICL accuracy, macro F1) | | |
| real data (published UB) | 0.014, 0.027 | 84.41, 75.68 |
| AIM (published) | 0.017, 0.034 | 83.36, 76.10 |
| Tab-PE (published) | 0.049, 0.086 | 82.22, 73.66 |
| Tab-PE, our run of their code, three seeds | 0.044, 0.093 | 82.19, 72.96 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B, three seeds | 0.040, 0.100 | 81.44, 74.46 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-32B, three seeds | 0.039, 0.101 | 81.42, 74.98 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B, three seeds | 0.088, 0.176 | 81.75, 74.10 |
| maximum-entropy decoder, three seeds | 0.045, 0.109 | 81.97, 76.55 |
| reference AIM, three seeds | 0.022, 0.061 | 81.69, 70.84 |
| reference MST, three seeds | 0.023, 0.062 | 80.86, 64.68 |

**E.7 Other budgets.** The reference AIM and MST at $\varepsilon = 0.5$ and 1 under our protocol (five draws on Adult and five on NHANES), with the Qwen2.5-7B CoRTeC configuration and the release's own maximum-entropy decoder at the same budgets (three draws; the decoder's $\varepsilon = 2$ rows repeat Table 3), and the DP-LLMTGen protocol at $\varepsilon = 0.5$. The $\varepsilon = 2$ rows of Table 3 are the reference. At $\varepsilon = 0.5$ and 1, the decoder improves on the 7B configuration on single columns, pairs and every student at both sizes, so that configuration's errors come from the backbone and not from the release. The reference AIM fits the private table more closely than the decoder at every budget. At $n = 300$ and $\varepsilon = 0.5$ the decoder's students score higher (0.819, 0.855 and 0.850 against 0.811, 0.814 and 0.787, one split).

| Adult, $n = 300$ | ε | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | cond. held-out | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| reference AIM | 0.5 | 0.050 | 0.126 | 0.061 | 0.084 | 0.811 | 0.814 | 0.787 |
| reference AIM | 1 | 0.054 | 0.125 | 0.078 | 0.051 | 0.823 | 0.859 | 0.830 |
| reference MST | 0.5 | 0.053 | 0.129 | 0.132 | 0.054 | 0.774 | 0.810 | 0.780 |
| reference MST | 1 | 0.051 | 0.127 | 0.144 | 0.042 | 0.741 | 0.798 | 0.754 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B | 0.5 | 0.127 | 0.255 | 0.066 | 0.060 | 0.754 | 0.826 | 0.809 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B | 1 | 0.115 | 0.223 | 0.122 | 0.067 | 0.763 | 0.826 | 0.798 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B | 2 | 0.110 | 0.220 | 0.090 | 0.054 | 0.813 | 0.852 | 0.830 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 0.5 | 0.086 | 0.190 | 0.074 | 0.071 | 0.819 | 0.855 | 0.850 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 1 | 0.066 | 0.157 | 0.069 | 0.060 | 0.821 | 0.859 | 0.857 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 2 | 0.058 | 0.146 | 0.082 | 0.049 | 0.818 | 0.856 | 0.847 |
| **Adult, $n = 1{,}000$** | | | | | | | | |
| reference AIM | 0.5 | 0.037 | 0.087 | 0.037 | 0.031 | 0.841 | 0.880 | 0.873 |
| reference AIM | 1 | 0.033 | 0.080 | 0.051 | 0.032 | 0.837 | 0.873 | 0.861 |
| reference MST | 0.5 | 0.032 | 0.089 | 0.135 | 0.037 | 0.758 | 0.806 | 0.791 |
| reference MST | 1 | 0.032 | 0.086 | 0.136 | 0.044 | 0.781 | 0.817 | 0.802 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B | 0.5 | 0.107 | 0.208 | 0.052 | 0.046 | 0.808 | 0.863 | 0.848 |

| Adult, $n$ = 300 | ε | 1-way TV | 2-way TV | cond. seen | cond. held-out | TSTR-LR | TSTR-RF | TSTR-GBM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B | 1 | 0.095 | 0.183 | 0.078 | 0.044 | 0.807 | 0.853 | 0.840 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B | 2 | 0.089 | 0.178 | 0.061 | 0.039 | 0.808 | 0.855 | 0.849 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 0.5 | 0.078 | 0.164 | 0.034 | 0.062 | 0.817 | 0.864 | 0.854 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 1 | 0.052 | 0.123 | 0.036 | 0.048 | 0.819 | 0.867 | 0.857 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | 2 | 0.041 | 0.106 | 0.034 | 0.045 | 0.826 | 0.870 | 0.863 |
| **NHANES, $n$ = 300** | | | | | | | | |
| reference AIM | 0.5 | 0.053 | 0.122 | 0.025 | 0.046 | 0.716 | 0.681 | 0.665 |
| reference AIM | 1 | 0.040 | 0.104 | 0.040 | 0.042 | 0.716 | 0.709 | 0.693 |
| reference MST | 0.5 | 0.050 | 0.126 | 0.033 | 0.063 | 0.704 | 0.655 | 0.642 |
| reference MST | 1 | 0.045 | 0.109 | 0.027 | 0.046 | 0.703 | 0.658 | 0.622 |
| Tab-PE (1,000-row population) | 0.5 | 0.163 | 0.280 | 0.028 | 0.048 | 0.702 | 0.674 | 0.667 |
| Tab-PE (1,000-row population) | 1 | 0.098 | 0.184 | 0.053 | 0.049 | 0.701 | 0.682 | 0.653 |

| DP-LLMTGen protocol, ε = 0.5 | 1-way | 2-way | 3-way | 4-way | 5-way | ACC | AUC |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| DP-LLMTGen (published) | 0.058 | 0.095 | 0.126 | 0.154 | 0.183 | 0.833 | 0.887 |
| RAP++ (published) | 0.066 | 0.116 | 0.162 | 0.208 | 0.251 | 0.766 | 0.758 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B (ours) | 0.075 | 0.145 | 0.225 | 0.320 | 0.424 | 0.833 | 0.885 |
| maximum-entropy decoder (ours) | 0.049 | 0.112 | 0.193 | 0.293 | 0.409 | 0.819 | 0.882 |
| reference AIM (ours) | 0.021 | 0.057 | 0.106 | 0.173 | 0.259 | 0.821 | 0.845 |
| reference MST (ours) | 0.020 | 0.061 | 0.117 | 0.190 | 0.281 | 0.808 | 0.823 |
| DP fine-tuned Llama-2 7B, our run | 0.103 | 0.181 | 0.253 | 0.329 | 0.412 | 0.772 | 0.815 |
| *training set, our scorer* | *0.009* | *0.025* | *0.057* | *0.112* | *0.190* | *0.877* | *0.931* |

The published Tab-PE row's embedding-space precision and recall are 34.3 and 77.3. Our Tab-PE rerun reads 66.7 and 74.6, and our CoRTeC rows 61 to 72 and 71 to 84, with a 64-16-64 autoencoder trained for each run. The precision column therefore depends on the implementation and is not compared.

**E.8 Stage C on NHANES.** We use the rule the implementation ships. The tolerance is derived from the release (0.107 for the auto-configured release), and no verdict is given while a released cell holds fewer than 20 synthetic rows. Under that rule, no single 300-row draw receives a verdict, because two or three of the four released cells are thin. The three draws pooled (900 rows) are within the bound at 0.087, against the tolerance of 0.107. The real-sample ceiling passes at 0.088 and the permuted floor fails at 0.139, so the verdict holds at 95 % simultaneous confidence over the four cells. Stage C cost ε = 1 on top of the release's ε = 2.

## Appendix F. Membership Inference, Distance to Closest Record and Memorisation

**F.1 Membership inference.** We use the standard membership game [33] in the form Stadler et al. apply to synthetic data [34]. There are 3,000 candidates, half from the training split and half held out. The adversary sees the three draws of $n$ = 300 (900 rows) and must say whether each candidate was in the training set. We run four attacks: nearest-neighbour distance, a discriminative shadow model, a per-record likelihood-ratio test in the style of Carlini et al. [11] over sixteen bootstrap density models, and exact matching. The advantage is $2 \cdot \mathrm{AUC} - 1$. The positive control passes 900 real training rows off as synthetic. On Adult, the 1,500 member candidates are drawn from a training split of 26,048 rows, so only a few of them can be among those 900 rows. The control's exact-match advantage is therefore small: 0.098 as measured. On NHANES, whose training split has 2,999 rows, it is 0.48. The other three attacks separate the control on both datasets.

| configuration, ε = 2 | dataset | strongest advantage (attack) | nearest-neighbour AUC (95 %) | exact matches |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B | Adult | 0.022 (shadow model) | 0.491 (0.477 to 0.506) | 0 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-32B (AWQ) | Adult | 0.035 (likelihood ratio) | 0.492 (0.478 to 0.507) | 0 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-8B | Adult | 0.026 (nearest neighbour) | 0.487 (0.473 to 0.502) | 0 |
| CoRTeC, Gemini 3.6 Flash | Adult | 0.022 (nearest neighbour) | 0.489 (0.475 to 0.503) | 0 |
| CoRTeC, anonymised, Gemini 3.6 Flash | Adult | 0.021 (nearest neighbour) | 0.489 (0.475 to 0.504) | 0 |

| configuration, ε = 2 | dataset | strongest advantage (attack) | nearest-neighbour AUC (95 %) | exact matches |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| maximum-entropy decoder | Adult | 0.025 (nearest neighbour) | 0.488 (0.473 to 0.503) | 0 |
| maximum-entropy decoder with the selection step | Adult | 0.024 (likelihood ratio) | 0.493 (0.478 to 0.508) | 0 |
| auto-configured release, no model, with selection | Adult | 0.025 (likelihood ratio) | 0.488 (0.475 to 0.503) | 0 |
| one-shot from the column names (no release) | Adult | 0.012 (nearest neighbour) | 0.494 (0.480 to 0.510) | 5 |
| reference AIM | Adult | 0.024 (nearest neighbour) | 0.488 (0.474 to 0.503) | 0 |
| reference MST | Adult | 0.032 (nearest neighbour) | 0.484 (0.470 to 0.499) | 0 |
| DP-2Stage, GPT-2 | Adult | 0.021 (shadow model) | 0.493 (0.478 to 0.507) | 0 |
| DP fine-tuned Qwen3-14B | Adult | 0.024 (likelihood ratio) | 0.493 (0.479 to 0.508) | 0 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B | NHANES | 0.026 (likelihood ratio) | 0.509 (0.478 to 0.537) | 0 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-32B (AWQ) | NHANES | 0.049 (likelihood ratio) | 0.516 (0.486 to 0.545) | 0 |
| maximum-entropy decoder | NHANES | 0.044 (likelihood ratio) | 0.503 (0.474 to 0.533) | 0 |
| reference AIM | NHANES | 0.048 (shadow model) | 0.506 (0.478 to 0.535) | 0 |
| reference MST | NHANES | 0.039 (shadow model) | 0.504 (0.473 to 0.533) | 0 |
| DP fine-tuned Qwen3-14B | NHANES | 0.060 (likelihood ratio) | 0.473 (0.445 to 0.501) | 0 |
| Tab-PE | NHANES | 0.037 (shadow model) | 0.511 (0.480 to 0.541) | 0 |
| *permitted advantage at ε = 2* | | *0.762* | | |

Every nearest-neighbour interval contains chance. These attacks bound leakage only as far as they are strong. A black-box audit of the kind Annamalai and De Cristofaro give for DP-SGD [2] would return an empirical ε instead of a null result, and is the natural next measurement. On Adult, the nearest-neighbour statistic reads slightly below chance for every method: CoRTeC, the decoder, AIM and MST alike. The private rows lie slightly farther from the synthetic rows than held-out rows do, which is a property of the split and the statistic, not of any method.

**F.2 Distance to the closest record.** For every synthetic row we compute the L1 distance to the nearest training row over the 15 Adult columns. Numerical columns are scaled to [0, 1] on the training split, and a categorical column counts 1 when it does not match. The reference curve is the real test split measured against the training split. Figure 4 shows the Adult configurations at ε = 2. None contains an exact copy of a training row, while the real test split itself contains 0.11 % exact duplicates. The medians are 0.145 for real held-out rows, 0.185 for the Gemini configuration, 0.19 for the reference AIM, 0.34 for MST, 0.38 and 0.44 for the Qwen3-14B configuration at the two sizes, 1.18 for the decoder, 1.8 for DP-2Stage, 3.6 for Tab-PE and 0.105 for the DP fine-tuned Qwen3-14B. The last of these is the smallest, so we ran a paired check. We compared each row's distance to a random 6,513-row subset of the training split with its distance to the 6,513-row test split. A generator that copies training rows sits closer to the first, and one that produces typical rows sits equally close to both. The share of rows closer to the training subset is between 0.47 and 0.54 for every configuration, against 0.50 expected, so the fine-tuned model's small distances reflect typical rows, not copying.

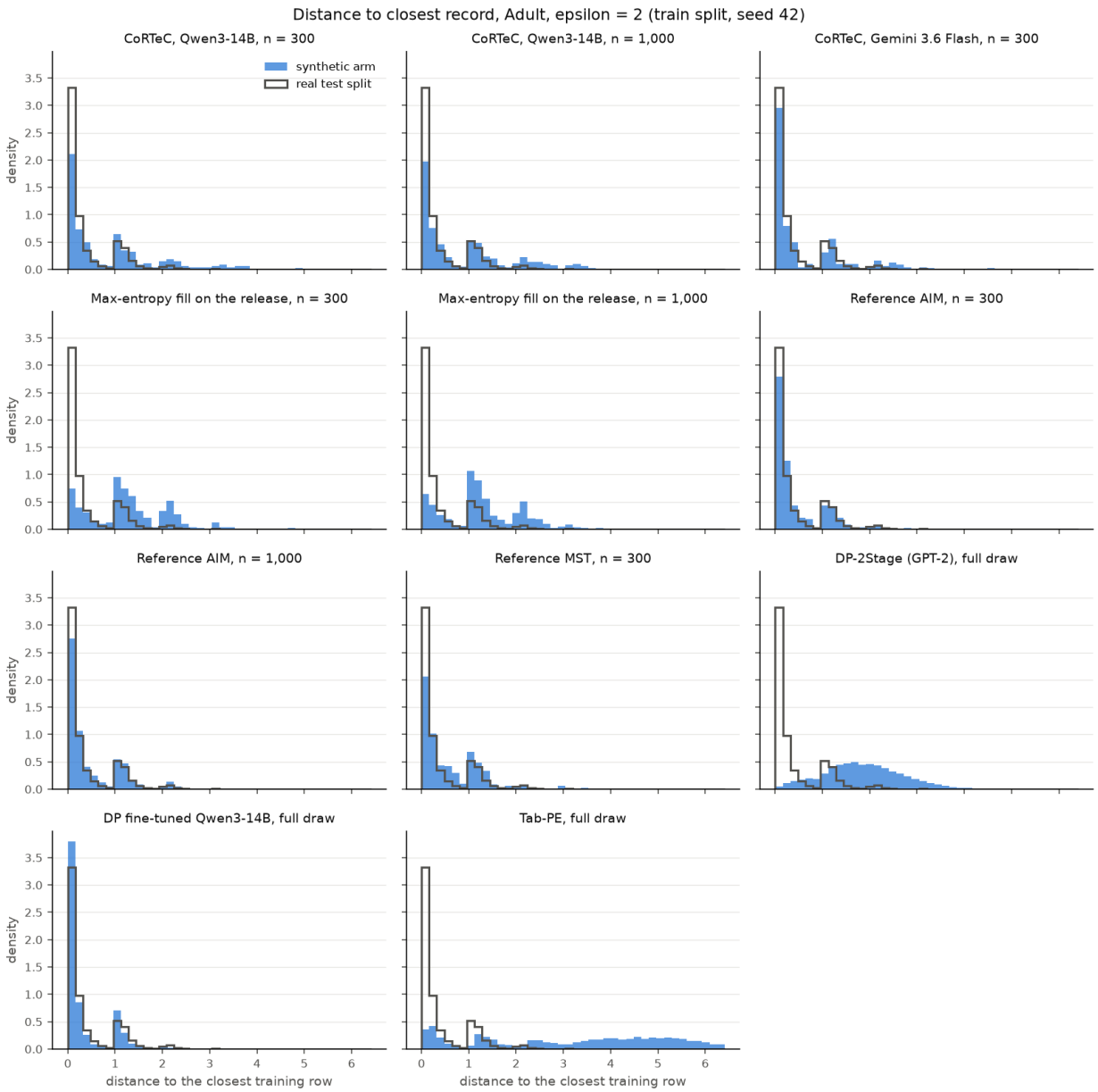



**Figure 4:** Distance to the closest training row, Adult at ε = 2, for each configuration against the curve of the real test split.

**F.3 Memorisation tests of the served backbone.** We ran the tests of Bordt, Nori and Caruana [4] (package tabmemcheck 0.1.6) on the Adult training file against gemini-3.6-flash, with reasoning off and temperature 0, in 304 calls. In the header test, given the header and the first characters of row 1, the model reproduced data rows 2 to 25 of the file verbatim, including the final-weight values. The opening of the Adult file appears in countless tutorials, and the model has memorised it, as prior work found for GPT-4. Row completion at random positions, with ten real rows as the prefix, succeeded 0 times in 25. Completion of the nearly unique final-weight column from the other fourteen succeeded 0 times in 25. The first-token test scored 8 of 25, against 7 of 25 for always choosing the most common token. In feature completion, each categorical column was predicted from the other columns for 25 rows with five examples. Every column was completed at or below the rate of a gradient-boosting classifier trained on the other columns: education 25 of 25 against a predictability of 1.00, occupation 7 of 25 against 0.39, workclass 14 of 25 against 0.76, relationship 22 of 25 against 0.79, and income 21 of 25 against 0.87. Every column was above the majority choice. This reflects knowledge of what the columns mean, which the anonymised control removes.

None of the file's first fifty rows appears in any CoRTeC draw on Gemini, named or anonymised, or on Qwen3-14B or 32B at either size. The one-shot control of Table 3, which has no release, shows what that recitation looks like in a draw. Of its rows, 208 to 211 of 300 and 697 to 703 of 1,000 are verbatim copies of the file's first 25 rows (22 to 24 distinct rows, each repeated about nine and thirty times). Its three $n = 300$ draws hold five exact matches among the

3,000 membership candidates, three members and two held out, which no attack turns into an advantage (0.012). Against the whole public file of 32,561 rows, no draw of any CoRTeC configuration, of the decoder with or without selection, or of the reference AIM holds a verbatim row. Rows that agree on the fourteen columns other than the nearly unique final weight occur in the CoRTeC draws at the reference AIM's rate (10 to 16 % against 8 to 14 % of a draw at $n = 300$). That is coincidence on a table with many near-duplicate rows, not copying. The Qwen3 backbones were not given these tests.

## Appendix G. An Indicative Summary in Percent

For a reader who wants one number per axis, we scale fidelity against a real sample of the same size and utility between the no-information floor and the ceiling. Fidelity % is 100 times the mean, over the four fidelity measures, of min(1, real-sample error / method error). So 100 means as close to the private table as a real sample of that size, and 50 means twice as far. Utility % is 100 times the mean, over the three students, of (method AUC − permuted-target AUC) / (ceiling AUC − permuted-target AUC), clipped to [0, 100]. Each row averages every dataset, $n$ and seed the configuration was run on at $\varepsilon = 2$, and the cells column counts them. The summary is indicative only and is not a ranking. The tables above are the evidence. Rows are ordered by the number of cells and then by fidelity. Configurations with one or two cells are single-split signals. The auto-configured release's fidelity mean uses the two marginal measures only, because its conditional cells are not comparable.

| **method** | **cells** | **fidelity %** | **utility %** |
|---|---|---|---|
| reference AIM | 14 | 78 | 85 |
| maximum-entropy decoder of the release | 14 | 72 | 86 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-14B | 14 | 68 | 79 |
| auto-configured release, no model, with selection | 6 | 93 | 93 |
| maximum-entropy decoder with the selection step | 6 | 89 | 91 |
| DP fine-tuned Qwen3-14B | 6 | 27 | 63 |
| DP fine-tuned Qwen2.5-7B | 6 | 26 | 61 |
| Tab-PE | 5 | 17 | 84 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-32B (AWQ) | 4 | 66 | 80 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen2.5-7B | 4 | 49 | 67 |
| DP fine-tuned Llama-2 7B | 4 | 21 | 71 |
| DP-2Stage, GPT-2 | 4 | 19 | 15 |
| CoRTeC, Qwen3-8B | 2 | 71 | 83 |
| one-shot from the column names (no release) | 2 | 23 | 85 |
| CoRTeC, Gemini 3.6 Flash | 1 | 96 | 86 |